



The Times My Hot Girlfriend Was Taken

4 stories about hot girlfriends

JJ Vale

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The Time My Friend Darren Came to Stay a Night

I buzzed him in and left the door cracked.

Talia peeked around the kitchen doorway, wiping her hands on a dish towel. “That him?” She was excited and nervous at the same time. I had told her too many stories about Darren.

“Yeah,” I said and I smirked. I knew the effect he had on women and Talia wasn’t used to guys like him. I thought it would be funny — he was 6-4 and built like a wide receiver. She would never expect a guy like him would be a friend of mine.

She nodded like she was super casual about it and nothing bothered her, but she adjusted her ponytail in the hall mirror and tugged her sleeves down to her wrists. The hoody she wore was soft, pale grey, and her bike shorts were tight, her usual around the home outfit.

I opened the door fully when I heard the stairs creak. Darren came up with a gym bag over his shoulder and a wide grin. It wasn’t his first time he’d shown up halfway across the country with nowhere to stay.

“Still ugly I see,” he said, stepping in.

“Still homeless,” I said.

We clapped shoulders. He dropped the bag inside the door and looked past me.

Talia smiled politely from down the hallway and stepped up from behind me. “Hey.”

“Hey back. Darren.” He held out a hand.

She shook it lightly, then tucked her hands deep in her hoody pocket, stretching it down over the front of her body. “I’m Talia, but I’m sure you already know that,” she said, and she chuckled and rolled her eyes. She nudged my shoulder with hers.

“Appreciate the couch,” he said.

I smirked at him and shook my head. Same old Darren I thought, and I shut the door.

“No worries,” Talia replied. “You want a beer?”

“God, yes.”

She turned for the fridge. Darren’s eyes stayed on her for half a second longer than he should have allowed himself. I think Talia surprised him, too. He wasn’t expecting me to be with someone like her.

He always got away with those long stares. Even back in college, he never rushed the glance but left it on them long enough to make them wonder if he was thinking something he shouldn’t say. But with a guy like him, none of them seemed to mind too much.

Talia handed him a bottle and leaned back on the counter playing it all cool and relaxed.

I watched her, not him, fascinated at her transformation, amused by it.

“You still doing that physical therapy stuff?” I said.

“Yep. High-end sports clinic now. In Boulder.”

“You like it?”

“I like working on bodies,” he said, then he smirked at Talia. “Knees, man. Nobody takes care of their knees,” he said back to me and he shook his head with his lips pursed. But he was still grinning.

Talia laughed a bit more than just politely. “That’s so true,” she said to me, kicking me to make me look. “My clients are always tearing something. I’m in massage,” she said back to Darren, “not PT, but same idea.”

“Oh yeah? Nice. Massage.”

She opened her mouth like she might say more, then closed it and looked down. I had no idea what she meant for me when she nudged me.

We moved to the living room after a quick bite. Darren stretched out on the end of the couch, one arm behind his head. Talia curled up in the middle with her legs under her, the hem of her hoody resting on bare thigh. I sat at the other end, half watching the movie and half tracking the energy between them. It was interesting, it was captivating, him surprised at her, and her showing me a side of herself that I’d not seen before. What was it? Showing off? Inspiration?

Darren laughed at something on screen and Talia glanced at him and laughed too. But not at the joke, at him. I bulged my eyes and pulled my chin in. Her eyes seemed to sparkle and it made me smirk. She wasn’t hiding much.

The movie played on, something with too much dialogue and dim lighting. I kept waiting for the plot to kick in, but it seemed to never come.

Talia shifted beside me, tucked a throw pillow between her knees, and stretched her hoody down, even though it still barely reached past her shorts. Darren didn't say much. He sipped his beer, the bottle resting against his chest, eyes on the screen like he was alone in the room.

"You ever seen this one?" I asked.

He didn't look away. "Nah. Feels like one of those movies where nobody smiles for two hours and then someone dies in the rain."

Talia snorted, then covered her mouth like she hadn't meant to laugh so hard. "It won a bunch of awards," she said, defensively.

Darren glanced over at her, eyes lazy. "I like your laugh better than the movie. You should be in it."

She blinked then looked down and tucked her feet under the pillow. Did I detect a blush? I felt her leg press lightly against mine. She was nudging me again.

Darren took another sip and sank down further to let his head fully rest back against the couch cushion. Everybody was getting more relaxed, which was good. I thought Talia would find Darren too much and too loud, and Darren would find Talia too conservative and too quiet. But that wasn't true at all.

Twenty minutes passed, everyone quiet except for the occasional comment. Darren's phone lit up and he ignored it. Talia got up during a slow scene and padded into the kitchen without saying a word. The hem of her shorts rode up as she reached into the cupboard for popcorn, the neckline of her hoody sliding off her shoulder to show the black straps of her bra.

She brought the bowl to the couch. Darren reached in and their hands brushed, but neither of them mentioned it, they just glanced at each other and smiled lightly.

The scene on screen shifted to something somber, a funeral or maybe a dream. I wasn't watching anymore. Darren's hand went back into the bowl, slower this time, fingers trailing against the inside edge. Talia didn't move. She held the bowl on her lap, one hand resting lightly against the curve of it, the other pressed beneath the pillow between her knees. She seemed distracted.

"Cold in here?" Darren asked, not looking at her.

"A little," she said, barely above a whisper.

I reached for the remote. "I'll turn the heat up."

Darren stretched his legs out and looked over his shoulder. “You don’t have to. I’ll grab a top in a bit.”

“I’m fine,” Talia added quickly.

She pulled the sleeves of her hoody down to her knuckles, then tucked her chin in like she was settling in for good.

I threw a blanket over her lap anyway. I stayed a few minutes longer but my eyes were heavy. When I got up to go brush my teeth, Talia looked up at me and smiled gently.

“You going to bed?” she asked.

“Yeah. I’m wiped.”

“Okay,” she said, eyes soft. “I might finish this one.”

I was now officially shocked, but I didn’t show it. Talia choosing to remain alone with one of my friends, let alone with Darren, was a big step for her.

Darren didn’t say anything but he also didn’t move. They were nearly leaning on each other. The couch they sat on together was already designated as his bed.

In the bathroom, I left the door open and the light off, letting the dim hallway glow guide me. I brushed my teeth slowly, not because I was tired, but because I didn’t want to go back out there, not yet. Their voices drifted in faintly from the living room, low and conversational, with no urgency in them at all. I loved that they were getting along so well.

I caught the rise and fall of Talia’s voice, soft and smooth, followed by Darren’s deeper response. I couldn’t make out the words, but I could hear the shape of their conversation. She was asking him something, not rhetorical or polite, something she actually wanted to know. When he answered, she laughed with real amusement.

When I turned off the faucet, the apartment had fallen quiet again. Their voices had stopped. I waited, listening, but there was only the hum of the fridge and the faint buzz of the show still playing in the background.

I crossed to the bedroom, the floor cool beneath my feet. The room was dark, lit only by the hallway light. I got under the blankets but stared up at the ceiling, eyes open, thoughts circling the way they always did when I had things to think I didn’t want in my head.

I didn’t know how much time passed before I noticed she still hadn’t come to bed. I turned onto my side, reached out instinctively, and touched

the empty half of the mattress. The sheet was undisturbed, no indentation, no warmth. Nothing to suggest she'd been back at all.

I must have slept. I sat up and let my eyes adjust.

The apartment felt different, like something subtle had shifted in the air while I had been sleeping. I got up and moved back into the hallway, slower because I didn't want to be seen.

The living room glowed faintly from the television screen, now showing music videos, the music on light. Talia was still on the couch but curled into the blanket with her knees pulled up and her head resting on the cushion. She looked asleep, or close to it, her face turned slightly toward the screen, one hand under her cheek.

Darren was stretched out beside her, his long legs bent slightly and one arm resting against the back cushion and thrown around her shoulders. His eyes were closed, but his breathing was light. It was not the deep kind of breathing that came with sleep.

I stood in the hallway for a longer moment, unnoticed and unmoving before I turned back to the bedroom.

I left the door open when I lay back down but I wasn't sure why. Maybe I wanted to hear something, maybe I wanted to leave a trace of my presence, maybe the sound of my breathing down the hall could serve as a boundary. A boundary against what?

The sheets were warm. I lay still and tried to find a rhythm in the quiet, but everything felt suspended. The apartment wasn't asleep but it felt like it was waiting.

A sound came from the living room, subtle enough that I almost missed it, the soft rustle of fabric shifting against fabric. It was a slow repositioning of weight, like someone moving carefully to avoid being heard.

I closed my eyes to sharpen the rest of my senses. My mind played games on me like this all the time. I had no reason ever to question Talia.

The television volume had been turned up at some point. I could barely hear the occasional creak of the couch. I heard what might have been Darren clearing his throat, barely audible, followed by the whisper of the blanket being moved.

There was another pause. Then a new sound, quiet but distinct. Was it the wet click of lips parting? Was it a breath that caught and softened? Not speech, not laughter, but something smaller and more private.

I opened my eyes and stared into the darkness. There was a tightening in my chest, but not the kind I expected. It wasn't just jealousy. It wasn't even betrayal, not yet anyway. It was something else entirely, something lower, heavier, and more complex. I wasn't certain what I wanted to be true and what I wanted to be only my imagination. I only knew I wanted to understand what was going on out there, and why Talia wasn't in bed yet.

I pushed the blanket aside and sat up slowly. My feet touched the floor without making a sound. Half of me believed I would stand, walk to the hallway, and end the tension. The other half knew I wouldn't do that because I didn't want to stop it, what might have been happening out there. And that was a strange thing to feel.

I wanted to know what Talia might actually do if she thought I had gone to sleep. Not because I didn't trust her, but because I had seen something in her that evening that didn't match the girl I thought I knew. I wanted to know more.

She was still the quiet, gentle, warm being I always knew. But beneath that, there was a new current as though something was waking up inside her.

Darren had seen it. He didn't chase it. He didn't flirt. But he watched her with the kind of attention that made her stand taller, speak more carefully, smile with a trace of new certainty. She responded to him not with coyness or guilt, but with a kind of curiosity, and that was new.

I lay back down and pulled the blanket up and waited for whatever came next.

I didn't fall asleep. I just remained still and aware, breathing in the dark. If they were talking, it was only in glances, in motion. At some point, I must have blinked longer than I meant to, because the next sound I heard snapped me awake and straight into alertness.

Talia had never cheated at anything in her life. She used to apologize when her phone buzzed during dinner because it felt rude to check it while we were eating. Her bras matched her panties even when no one would ever see them, like she believed there was a right way to be dressed underneath. She kissed me slowly every morning, even when she was running late, and always made sure she was the last to break it off.

And yet the version of her that seemed to exist just down the hallway didn't belong to that list of habits.

Something had changed. And the worst part, the part I wasn't ready to admit to myself, was that I had felt it coming. Not just tonight and not just since Darren arrived, but longer than that. There had been something rippling just under the surface of her attention, something I couldn't say but that showed up in the way she touched her own neck while she read, or how she sat on the balcony with her thighs exposed to the sun and her eyes closed like she wanted someone to see her.

Maybe it had nothing to do with Darren, maybe he was just the first man close enough to catch it.

The couch creaked again, low and rhythmic, barely perceptible unless you were listening for it. It didn't sound like shifting for comfort, it sounded like restraint.

I stayed perfectly still. In that moment, the sick part of me, the part I hadn't known existed until now, realized I didn't want to interrupt it. I didn't want to know for sure, not yet. She wasn't the only one changing.

I wanted her to do it, I wanted her to go farther. Not because I wanted to lose her, but because I needed to see who she really was when I wasn't looking. I wanted Talia to do what she wanted.

I closed my eyes and listened harder. The next sound I heard was the unmistakable whisper of skin against skin, no fabric involved at all this time.

It was slow and measured. Controlled, like someone easing their way into a moment they'd imagined first and now didn't want to rush. It was the sound of someone trying very hard to not make any sound.

Then I heard her breathe in sharply through her teeth, and hold it.

Talia's POV

I could hear him breathing slow and evenly beside me though we both stared straight ahead at the show.

Darren hadn't moved for a while, at least, not in any way that said he was awake. His arm was still slung casually over the back of the couch, fingers draped over my shoulder, his hand now sliding to hang loosely down the front of me. He had stretched out the way you do when you went to bed, but I hadn't shifted away.

I told myself it was fine. We weren't even touching, not really. Certainly not in a way that meant anything.

The television had dimmed to that soft, idle glow, casting the room in a flickering blue. It painted blue the floor, the edges of his chest, the inside of my thighs where the blanket had slipped. I hadn't meant to fall into this position with him, half-curved in, back pressed to the cushion, hips angled toward him.

I had meant to go to bed. I had even stood up at one point, holding the edge of the blanket, but he looked over at me and smiled, and something about the way he remained still made me want to sit back down.

He didn't reach for me and he didn't even flirt with me. He just stayed where he was and let me decide how close I wanted to be. That was what made it worse. Or maybe better.

"I can't tell if you're asleep yet," I whispered.

His head turned slightly toward me. He didn't open his eyes, but his voice was low and quiet.

"I'm not and you know that."

I felt my breath catch. Not because I was afraid, but because something about hearing him say that, his voice so soft, and with no suggestion in it, unlocked the part of me I had been trying to keep down the last few weeks or months.

I let the blanket fall away from my arms. My skin prickled in the air, but I didn't pull the fabric back up. I wasn't cold.

The soft cotton of my hoodie clung lightly to the shape of my breasts. I had chosen the bra for comfort, but it was still one of my pretty ones, deep wine-colored lace with a satin edge that peeked just faintly along the neckline. The straps were thin and matched the waistband of the panties underneath. I never thought anyone would see them tonight, I wear things like that just for me. I wasn't sure if I wanted him to see, but I wasn't sure I didn't. That's the part that was coming unlocked in me.

"You're quiet," he said, still not looking directly at me.

"I'm just thinking," I murmured.

"What about?"

I hesitated. Then I pulled my legs up onto the couch, folding them beneath me, letting my thigh brush his leg, not hard, but enough to be felt.

"I'm not even sure."

He smiled faintly, eyes still closed. "Okay then."

He didn't move away. I looked down at my hands resting in my lap. My nails traced the hem of my top, pulled it higher until the smooth band of my

waistband was exposed in the flickering light.

I didn't stop. I didn't look at him when I slid my fingers under the hem of my hoody. I let the fabric gather as I pulled upward, slow enough to feel the cool air meet each inch of my skin. My stomach tensed automatically, not from fear, but from the quiet pressure of being seen, even if his eyes were still closed.

I wanted to be seen.

The fabric passed over my bra, lifting against it, catching for a moment along the strap before I raised it higher. I paused at my ribs, holding the bunched cotton against my chest, half-covered and fully aware of it. The movement had made my breathing shallow.

He still hadn't opened his eyes. Or maybe he had, and I wasn't brave enough to look.

I pulled the hoody off in one smooth motion, letting it fall beside the couch cushion. The air touched my shoulders, then the tops of my breasts, and I felt the lace of my bra contract slightly as I exhaled. It wasn't the chill that made me breathe that way.

My legs shifted on the cushion. My thighs pressed together and then relaxed again, spreading just enough for my knees to angle outward under the blanket, which now only covered the lower half of my legs.

I traced the inside of my wrist with my thumb, as if steadying myself, but my attention was on the smooth line of his chest, the slow movement of his breath, the curve of his shoulder in the television light.

His head tilted toward me.

"You still busy thinking?"

His voice was lower now, and the way he said it wasn't playful, it was careful and measured.

I nodded, then realized he couldn't see it. "Yes."

His eyes opened then. Not fully, just enough for me to see the dark shape of them watching me. He didn't look down and he didn't let his gaze trail. He just looked directly into my eyes and somehow that made me more aware of my body than if he had stared at my chest.

My fingers moved to the waistband of my shorts. I didn't yank them and I didn't make a show of it. I simply lifted my hips an inch and slid the fabric down over my hips, inch by inch, watching him the entire time to see if he would look away.

He didn't.

The shorts slipped past my thighs, down over my knees, and gathered at my ankles. I kicked them off and let them rest on the floor. My legs settled back onto the couch, bare now except for the deep wine panties that matched the bra, scalloped edges, delicate mesh, the kind of set I wore only ever for myself.

Except tonight, I didn't feel like behaving just for me anymore.

He didn't reach for me. That would have been easier, if he had taken control, if he had made the first move. I could have let it happen without owning it. But Darren stayed exactly where he was, eyes on mine, breath steady, hands resting against the cushion like he had no intention of breaking the wall unless I did.

He forced me to decide. I could have pulled the blanket up. I could have stood. I could have whispered goodnight and gone to bed.

Instead, I moved closer. Just a few inches at first, enough for my knees to brush against his thigh. My skin met his through the fabric of his shorts, and even that minimal contact sent something warm down my spine. I didn't pull away, but I waited, yet he still didn't touch me.

He only said one thing. "Are you sure?"

I almost laughed, but it caught in my throat. Not because it was funny, but because it sounded like something from a different version of this night, one where I wasn't already half-undressed, sitting beside him in matching fancy lingerie, my chest rising faster than I wanted him to see.

I nodded slowly.

Then I reached for his hand. It felt heavy in my grip. His fingers were long, warm, a little rough. I pulled them toward me and placed them on my thigh just above the knee. I didn't guide him higher and I didn't push. I just left him there, palm against bare skin, feeling the weight of that contact settle into the space between us.

His hand remained still for a moment, as though absorbing the moment. Then his thumb began to move, slowly tracing along the inside of my thigh, pressing gently in a path back and forth with no urgency, no escalation. He let his touch become familiar before it became anything else.

I exhaled and closed my eyes. The muscles in my legs responded immediately, not with tension, but with that slow, melting heat that started in the deepest part of my stomach. My hips shifted forward by instinct and the edge of the cushion met me differently now, more pressure where I wanted none, more resistance than I was ready to admit I was chasing.

His fingers never left my skin. They didn't rush and they didn't prod, they only circled and smoothed, a quiet exploration just beneath the surface of what I'd let him see.

When his fingertips moved an inch higher, I didn't stop him. I didn't even open my eyes.

The moment his fingers brushed the edge of my panties, I felt everything tighten.

Not out of fear, or shame, but because I had never been touched like this without being kissed, without being held, without anything to announce what was starting.

There was something terrifyingly intimate about how quiet it was. His fingertips moved along the fabric, slowly tracing the curve where the lace met my skin. He wasn't exploring blindly, he wasn't trying to get somewhere. He was feeling me, mapping the line of my body through touch alone.

I shifted my hips an inch forward, just enough for the cushion to give. The fabric of the panties grew tighter against me, drawing more awareness to every slight movement. My breathing was no longer steady. Each inhale dragged through my nose, shallow and uneven, and I knew he could hear it, too.

He didn't look at my face. His eyes were on my stomach, on his own hand, on the way my skin moved under his fingers. There was no smirk, no expression of possession, only attention and focus.

The edge of his thumb moved lower, pressing lightly against the center seam of the fabric. He didn't slip beneath it, he only applied the slightest pressure, enough for the sensation to land. My body answered without my control. I felt the heat rise sharply, not just between my legs, but across my chest, up the sides of my neck, into my scalp.

He dragged his hand back slowly, retracing the same line down my thigh. When it returned, the touch was firmer, more deliberate, two fingers now following the path, then flattening to press against the mound of fabric between my legs.

The lace was warm and damp with arousal I hadn't consciously noticed. When his palm pressed down, the mesh clung tighter. The contact wasn't invasive, it was encompassing. Every part of me beneath it responded at once.

My mouth parted, but no sound came. His hand paused, but not in hesitation but rather in acknowledgment that he felt it too.

I opened my eyes and looked at him. He met my gaze calmly, not questioning, not daring, but watching.

I heard something in the hallway and twisted around. He pulled his hand away and I stared into the half-open bedroom door, but Eli was sound asleep in there. I brought his hand back to me.

His fingers moved again, this time with purpose. Not hard and not rushed but with enough pressure to slide along the wet lace, drawing a slow, careful line. He used the heel of his palm to press down while his fingers circled, coaxing more heat from me, pulling sensation from deep inside me and spreading it outward.

I pressed my thighs together around his hand, not to stop him, but to feel him more fully. The pressure amplified everything, made my pulse roar in my ears, made my hips tilt up toward his touch.

Still, he didn't push past the fabric. He kept his hand still for one breath, then two. The weight of it settled low against me, his fingers relaxed, the heat of his palm radiating through the thin mesh. I felt the shape of him, broad across my lower belly, the pads of his fingers resting against the line of my lips through the fabric, and I wanted him to move again, but I didn't say it. I only shifted my hips a fraction forward, letting the signal speak clearly for me.

His fingers slid down slowly, following the damp center of my panties, pressing just enough to part me beneath the fabric. The motion wasn't rushed, and it wasn't clumsy. He explored like he already knew what he'd find, like he had been imagining this exact feeling and wanted to check whether it matched what he'd pictured.

When his fingertips reached the edge of the lace, he paused. He didn't speak and he didn't look at me. He only lifted the fabric gently, running his fingers under the waistband, and began to slip beneath it.

The contact was immediate. His touch met bare skin for the first time, and every nerve answered at once. I inhaled through my teeth and held the breath in my chest. His fingers moved lower, not deep, just enough to find the wetness that had already spread along the edge of my opening. He lingered there, easing through it, gathering it slowly, his hand cupped against me in a way that made my thighs tighten, shake.

I didn't resist. I let my legs spread just slightly, welcoming the contact without asking for more. His fingertips dragged up between my folds with excruciating slowness, careful not to go inside, not even to press too hard. He stayed shallow, letting me feel the contrast, how delicate it was, how precise, how completely in control of my body he was.

My hands had drifted to my thighs without me realizing. I dug my nails lightly into the skin, not to brace, but to stay centered. My whole body had gone warm. My breasts ached inside the bra, full and tight, nipples stiff against the lace. I wanted to be touched there too, but I didn't want to lose what he was doing.

When his thumb found my clit, he didn't circle it. He only pressed once, gently, holding the contact for a breath. The sensation hit me hard, hot, sharp, almost unbearable in how restrained it was. Then he pulled his hand back slowly, dragging through every inch again on the way down, not retreating but reinforcing everything he had just touched.

I let out a breath I didn't know I was holding.

He didn't speak and neither did I.

I leaned back against the couch cushion letting my shoulders settle deeper into it, my body open beneath him now. The panties were still in place, barely, stretched taut from where he'd slipped under, but the rest of me felt uncovered, exposed in ways that had nothing to do with fabric.

His hand drifted down again, then paused, resting lightly against the inside of my thigh. I knew what he was waiting for. He let me decide every step.

I reached behind my back without saying anything. The clasp was small, familiar, and my fingers found it easily. I hesitated but only once, just a flicker of pause, maybe even a tease, before I unhooked it.

The bra loosened. The straps slipped from my shoulders and slid down my arms, catching briefly on my elbows before I let it fall to the side. I didn't toss it or fold it. I just let it go. My arms dropped back to my sides, and I remained still.

The air met my skin instantly, cool against the heat that had built across my chest. I could feel how hard I'd become, nipples tight, aching, the whole weight of my breasts sensitized. Every shift made them move differently now, no longer held in place. I was conscious of how they sat, how they rose with each breath, how exposed I felt even in the dim flicker of the television.

Darren didn't reach immediately. His gaze moved over me, not leering, not devouring, just taking it in, like he had waited for this view long enough that he didn't want to blink through it.

Then his hand moved. He raised it slowly and brought his fingertips to my sternum, just below the base of my neck. From there, he traced down between my breasts, not touching them directly, not yet, just outlining the path his hands might take if I didn't stop him. And I didn't stop him.

When his palm finally cupped my right breast, the warmth of it made me shiver. He held it fully, not squeezing, just letting it fill his hand. His thumb brushed across the tip, then again, and the sensation sent a pulse of arousal straight down through my stomach. My back arched. The second time he circled it, slower now, my lips parted and I exhaled audibly.

He leaned in then, finally breaking the space between us, not with his mouth, but with both hands.

His other hand found my left breast and mirrored the motion, palms steady, thumbs grazing in quiet rhythm. He wasn't playing with me, he was learning me, testing how I reacted, what made me tense, what made me melt.

My thighs tightened again and I could feel how wet I had become. It was no longer possible to pretend this was still only in the realm of suggestion.

His hands left my chest without urgency. He trailed them down my sides as he moved, letting his fingertips skim along the curve of my waist, past my hips, and lower, until they rested against the inside of my thigh again. The skin there felt hypersensitive now, warmed, exposed, waiting.

I was already parted. He had done that earlier without taking anything from me. He had only touched, only explored. But the ache had grown worse since then. My body wasn't tense, it was ready. Everything in me leaned into the moment. There was no space left for doubt.

He slid his hand back between my legs. The panties clung wetly to me, the lace slick where it had pressed against the center. He didn't hesitate this time. His fingers slipped beneath the fabric, and when he reached the warm slickness underneath, he exhaled through his nose, low and quiet.

His touch was more certain now. He didn't move quickly, but he moved with intent.

I felt one finger glide along the length of me, slow and steady, parting everything again with just enough pressure to open me. The heat there was

undeniable, the wetness more than enough. He circled once at the top, dragging the sensation upward, before dipping lower.

When he entered me, he did it carefully. My body answered instantly. I tightened around him, my hips shifting down and forward to meet the motion, and I felt the length of his finger press inward, knuckle by knuckle, until it was fully inside me. The stretch was subtle, but I felt every inch of it, every pulse, every twitch of muscle in response.

He paused once he was in, giving me time, letting me feel it. Then he began to move, slow and rhythmic. Each withdrawal was gentle, followed by the slow push back in. My thighs opened farther to allow him. I didn't even think about the motion, my body made room for him on its own.

His other hand slid back to my hip, anchoring me, holding me in place while he worked. The rhythm was calm and controlled. There was no rushing with him, no force. Just a steady, gliding pressure that grew warmer with each pass. He curved his finger slightly on the next thrust, and I gasped, not from pain, but from the sudden brightness of sensation deep inside me.

My mouth opened, but nothing came out.

He curved again, slower this time, testing the angle. I tilted my hips up to meet it, pressing against his palm, and I could feel my own wetness spreading down to the back of his hand.

Then a second finger joined the first. I was already lifting my hips for him. The second finger slid in beside the first with a slow, steady pressure that filled me completely. My body yielded easily, but I still felt every new inch, how the stretch deepened, how the walls of my body wrapped tighter around him in response. The heat inside me pulsed with each movement, rising with a sharp clarity that narrowed my awareness to nothing but the places where we touched.

He kept his rhythm exact. Each stroke moved slowly, not pulling all the way out, not rushing back in. He stayed inside me, easing in deeper, adjusting the angle just slightly with each pass until he found the one that made my legs tremble. When his fingertips curled upward and pressed against the front of me, I arched my back in reflex. The breath I let out was broken, not from panic, but from how precisely he had found the spot that made everything tighten around him involuntarily.

I grabbed the edge of the cushion beside me, grounding myself, anchoring to something solid while my hips rocked forward and back. My

skin burned with the tension building behind my ribs, low and heavy, tightening like a cord being pulled from somewhere beneath my navel.

He said nothing. His mouth stayed closed. His breath was quiet and steady, but was heavier now as his eyes followed every response I gave him. There was no gloating in his expression, no smugness. Just that same calm certainty of his, now turned inward on me.

His thumb found my clit again, this time bare, slick, fully exposed. He didn't circle. He pressed lightly, holding the contact for two full strokes of his fingers inside me before he moved again. The pressure was perfect, soft at first, then firmer, never frantic. It matched the rhythm of what he was doing deeper inside me, drawing sensation from both directions and pushing it all toward the center of me.

My legs were shaking now with the kind of tremble that starts low and spreads outward when release is coming closer than you're ready for. I didn't want to let go yet. I wanted to stay inside the feeling, stay in the moment of being touched like this, held open and carefully explored, like my body was being read rather than used.

But I was already too close. The pressure was too exact, the motion too steady. My muscles pulled tighter with every thrust, my breathing short and open, mouth parted with no sound coming out.

He didn't change his pace. He didn't speed up or demand anything from me. He only kept going exactly as he was, letting my body decide the rest.

It didn't come as a crash. It was a long, rising wave that didn't stop when I thought it would, a heat that poured outward in slow, rolling pulses as my back arched and my eyes shut tight against the sensation taking hold of everything. I covered my mouth and clenched my eyes.

My body stayed arched for a moment, my hips lifting into his hand, thighs trembling as the last of the wave moved through me. The release had taken more from me than I expected. It didn't empty me, it left me wide open and full in a way that felt more physical than emotional. Every part of me still pulsed with the echo of it, even as my muscles slowly began to unclench.

I let my back sink into the cushion, my chest rising and falling in shallow waves, my arms limp at my sides. The air in the room felt different now, denser, warmer against my skin, or maybe it was just my skin that had changed. I could still feel the path his hands had taken on me, not as

memory but as presence, as though my body had memorized the shape of him and now expected him to stay exactly where he was.

His fingers withdrew slowly. He didn't pull away with haste or hesitation. He moved with the same precision he had used to enter me, sliding out gently, letting my body close around the absence as it adjusted. I felt the wetness spread slightly as he pulled free, the faint drag of his skin against mine, the soft brush of fabric as he pulled his hand clear of the panties.

My breath caught at the change, not in resistance, but in awareness. The cool air met me again between my legs, and I realized how soaked the fabric had become, how closely it clung to me now, how unmistakably exposed I would be if I stood.

He didn't speak. He wiped his hand lightly on the edge of the blanket and then placed it on my thigh again, this time just resting there. Not exploring, not requesting anything more, but holding contact while I came back into myself.

I opened my eyes and looked at him. He was watching me the same way he had before, still calm, still waiting. There was no triumph in his face, no pride in what he'd done to me, only the kind of attention that stays fixed on someone because it doesn't want to miss what comes next.

I reached down and adjusted my panties, smoothing them gently against my hips. They were damp enough to cling and the motion reminded me of what he had done, of what I had let him do, and of how completely I had wanted it.

His hand moved off my leg slowly as I sat up. I didn't speak. I only leaned forward resting my elbows on my knees, letting my hair fall forward while I caught my breath. My heart was still beating hard. I had let him inside me. And I wanted more.

I stayed forward for a few breaths, head lowered, eyes fixed on the carpet between my feet. My body still hummed with aftershocks, not from the orgasm itself, but from how controlled it had all been, how completely I had stayed aware the entire time, never taken, never pushed. I had chosen every second of it.

I sat upright and turned toward him.

He hadn't moved. His back was still pressed back against the couch, one hand resting loosely on his thigh, the other draped over the cushion behind him. His chest rose evenly and his eyes were on me.

I shifted toward him on my knees, crossing the cushion slowly, straddling his lap without hesitation but also without rushing. My thighs settled against his, knees pressing into the cushion on either side of his hips. The blanket slid down behind me, pooling at the small of my back. My chest was bare, still flushed, still sensitive from how he had touched me. The damp panel of my panties pressed lightly against the front of his shorts. I felt the heat of him immediately.

He exhaled through his nose, not heavily, but with intention. His hands rose to my hips, not to pull me down, but to hold me there.

I moved first. Not grinding, not testing, just adjusting, rocking forward to press against him, letting the fabric between us stretch tight, my wetness pushing into the cotton, the shape of him pressing back into me.

His eyes closed halfway, and I watched the line of his jaw tighten.

“You feel that?” I asked quietly and I smiled. I felt the control now.

His thumbs flexed gently against my hips. “Yeah.”

I rocked forward again, slower this time. The heat between us had nowhere to go, no space left. I wasn’t teasing, I wasn’t playing. I was preparing myself for the next step, and I needed to feel him through every layer first, needed the drag, the resistance, the proof of how badly I wanted him.

His hands slid around to the small of my back, resting just above the waistband of my panties. He just held me there, letting me stay in control, letting me move the way I needed to.

I rolled my hips and the fabric shifted, caught, then smoothed. I could feel how hard he was, how completely ready, and I knew he felt how wet I still was. The sensation wasn’t soft. It was direct, saturated, and unavoidable.

I reached down between us and hooked my fingers in the waistband of his shorts. I didn’t pull yet, I just held them there. My breath touched his mouth when I spoke again.

“Do you want me to take these off?”

His answer came without pause. “Yes.”

I leaned back just enough to make room between our bodies, then slowly lowered my hands to the waistband of his shorts. The fabric was soft, worn from use, stretched slightly from how he sat beneath me. I hooked my fingers underneath and began to ease them down, watching the way his stomach tightened as I moved.

His erection pressed upward, barely contained, the waistband catching against it before sliding lower. I didn't rush. I wanted to feel it pass beneath my fingers, wanted to take in how hard he already was before I even touched him skin to skin.

I watched his eyes as I worked the fabric down over his hips. He held my gaze the entire time. He didn't reach for me. He didn't lift his hips until I nudged him gently, and then he raised them just enough for the shorts to slide free.

He was bare now. Hard, thick, fully ready, the length of him exposed between us without anything left to hide. I had imagined what he'd look like, maybe not consciously, but now that I could see him, there was no room left for pretending I hadn't been curious.

I let my eyes stay on him, not for effect, not to tease, but because I needed to know what I was about to feel.

His cock rested against his stomach, smooth and dark and pulsing with heat. I placed one hand lightly on his thigh, just to steady myself, and shifted my weight forward again, letting the slick center of my panties press against him.

The contact made me exhale sharply through my nose. The soaked lace clung to me like a second skin. As I rocked forward, the wetness spread between us, dragging against the underside of him. The fabric added friction, texture, more sensation than I expected. I moved again, slower this time, tracing the length of him with the damp panel while he sat still, letting me use him the way I needed to.

His hands found my waist again. They held me with quiet pressure, not to guide, but to feel me move.

I pressed harder on the next pass, letting him slide between my folds through the fabric, letting the head of him catch slightly against the seam. I didn't lift. I didn't change the angle. I only shifted again, pressing more firmly, grinding slowly with a tension that made my thighs shake from the effort to stay controlled. I could keep an eye on the hallway and the dark bedroom straddling him this way.

Feeling safe, I reached down. I took the edge of the panties in two fingers and pulled them aside. I didn't take them off. I only opened myself.

Then I reached between us again, took him in my hand, and guided him forward. The head of him pressed against me flesh to flesh, warm and solid, held steady in my hand as I angled my hips forward. I guided him to the

opening, barely parting, just enough to feel the weight of what was coming settle exactly where I needed it. The first touch was almost nothing, just skin to skin, wetness to heat, but it landed with the kind of force that made my whole body draw tighter around the anticipation.

I kept my eyes on his. He didn't move. He stayed exactly where I placed him, hands resting lightly on my hips, fingers curled against the waistband of the panties I hadn't taken off. His eyes didn't flicker. He didn't watch between us. He only watched me, waiting.

I began to lower myself. The head of him slipped inside with the faintest resistance. I stopped breathing. My mouth opened, not in surprise, but in quiet effort as I adjusted, as my body stretched to take him. The pressure wasn't sharp. It was slow and full, blooming from the inside as I sank lower, inch by inch, the weight of him easing into me.

I inhaled sharply through my teeth. My thighs trembled as I settled deeper. The stretch made every inch register. There was no sudden thrust, no jolt of impact, only a steady, thick glide as I took him fully inside me.

He felt heavier than I imagined he would, harder, more present than any touch I had known before. I felt the slide of him inside me like a line being drawn, slow and continuous, from the very edge of my body to the core of it. My hands gripped his shoulders.

His jaw was locked, chest rising slower now, breath heavy but controlled. He didn't pull me down. He didn't buck his hips to meet mine. He only let me take him at the exact pace I chose.

When I reached the base of him, I paused. I stayed still, hips lowered, thighs trembling with the effort to hold myself steady. The fullness was complete. There was nothing left to take in, and yet my body still pulsed around him, aching for movement, even as I held myself in that stillness just a few seconds longer.

I looked down at him. He hadn't closed his eyes and neither had I.

I started to move. I lifted my hips slowly, not pulling away completely, only high enough to feel the length of him slide through me with steady resistance. The drag was thick and deliberate, the muscles inside me clinging to every inch of him, reluctant to let him go. When I reached the point just before he slipped free, I paused and lowered myself down again, the motion just as slow, just as exact.

The stretch met me the same way it had before, deep, full, and impossible to ignore.

I exhaled through parted lips, the sound caught somewhere between breath and soundless moan. My body was beginning to move on its own now, not wild or frantic, but with the natural rhythm of someone who had waited long enough to know what she wanted and wasn't willing to rush it.

His hands held my hips gently, letting me set the pace. He didn't thrust upward. He didn't take control. He only moved in response to me, his fingers tightening each time I came back down on him, as if he couldn't help anchoring himself to the movement.

I rode him slowly. Each rise and fall pulled another wave of pressure through me, deep and centered. The friction was warm and constant, the wet heat of my body wrapping tightly around him, making every stroke feel heavier, deeper, more consuming than the one before. My thighs worked in quiet rhythm, each shift of muscle controlled, steady, never frantic.

The fabric of my panties had twisted around one thigh, still pulled aside, the waistband taut where his hands rested. The elastic bit into my skin, a subtle contrast to the smooth motion happening beneath it. My breasts moved with each thrust, heavy and flushed, the nipples stiff, brushing against his chest when I leaned forward into the motion.

His breath deepened beneath me. But there was tension now, real tension, in the way he looked at me, as if he had to focus on something outside of his body to keep himself from losing the control he'd given me.

I shifted the angle, leaning farther forward on the next stroke, letting him fill me differently, lower, thicker, pressing into a part of me that made my back arch involuntarily. I gasped and adjusted again, chasing it, testing the angle, and when I found it again, I stayed there, hips moving in smaller, tighter circles now, grinding as much as thrusting.

His hands slid higher on my waist, gripping me tighter. I kept the motion steady, rolling my hips forward in slow, deliberate circles, the weight of him deep inside me with each pass. I didn't lift now, I stayed low, grinding instead of rising, letting the pressure build where it landed hardest, the base of him pressing into me in a way that made my thighs tense and my breath catch with every slow rotation.

He was silent beneath me. But his hands had changed. His grip had tightened around my waist, fingers digging in now, not hard, but with enough pressure to make his need unmistakable. His jaw was clenched, lips parted slightly, and his eyes had fallen halfway closed, not from detachment, but from focus. He was holding back.

I leaned forward more, letting my breasts brush his chest, my hands planted against his shoulders for balance. The new angle made the pressure inside me sharper, more insistent. I rode the motion in tighter loops, hips moving with the rhythm of someone who no longer needed to be careful.

He cursed under his breath, low, almost soundless. His hands slid from my waist to my hips, then to my lower back, pulling me down tighter against him. I didn't resist. I let him take that much, let him press me flush to him as he began to move underneath me, not to take over, but to meet the rhythm I had set.

The thrusts were shallow at first, more reaction than control. I felt him swell inside me, the change subtle but unmistakable. His body was tensing under mine, breath shortening, movements becoming more urgent with each second.

I didn't speed up. I stayed right where I was, letting him thrust up into me while I moved just enough to keep him buried, to keep that wet, tight friction constant. The sensation inside me sharpened again, not toward climax, but toward the kind of unbearable tension that begged to stay suspended.

His head dropped back. His grip locked. He thrust once, deeper, and then again, slower, but with a full-body tremor behind it. His breath caught, chest rising hard against mine, and I felt the final shift in him just before it happened.

The last few strokes were jerking, involuntary, his hips bucking beneath me with no rhythm left. I stayed pressed down, letting him empty into me, letting the heat pulse through every part of where we were joined.

He didn't make a sound. He only exhaled, slow and ragged, hands still clutching my waist like he couldn't quite let go.

I stayed on him, not moving, not speaking, my body still wrapped tightly around his, both of us held in the same quiet place we had just crossed into.

I stayed straddled across his hips, not out of indecision, but because my body hadn't released its grip on him yet. He was softening inside me, the heat of him still present, the wetness between us growing heavier with each slow breath. His hands remained on my waist, no longer pulling, only resting now, the tension in them beginning to ease.

Neither of us moved. The television had gone black, the screen idle and waiting, casting only a dim ambient glow. The room felt still in a different way now, like it had absorbed everything we'd done and wasn't ready to let

it go. I felt the weight of his thighs under mine, the slow rise and fall of his chest, the sheen of sweat cooling along the center of my back.

I lifted myself carefully. The withdrawal was thick and slow, my body reluctant to let go of the shape it had held. I felt the wetness slide between my legs, warm and unmistakable, trailing down the inside of my thigh as I stepped back onto the floor. My panties were still pulled aside. I adjusted them quietly, easing the lace back into place, though the fabric clung damp and useless against me now.

He watched me as I moved. He didn't ask anything and he didn't reach for me.

I bent and picked up my hoody from the floor, pulled it over my head without rushing. My bra remained somewhere beneath the couch. I didn't look for it. I only smoothed the fabric down my sides and turned toward the bedroom.

The apartment was silent. The clock on the stove glowed 4:19.

I walked barefoot down the hall. Each step felt deliberate, not heavy, but anchored in a different kind of awareness now, an unfamiliar calm wrapped around something I hadn't fully processed yet.

The bedroom door was still cracked. I pushed it open.

Eli was asleep, turned toward my side of the bed. The room was darker than the rest of the apartment. I crossed to the edge and sat for a moment, watching him, listening to the rhythm of his breath.

He didn't stir.

I slid beneath the covers, my body still warm, still open. The scent of the couch, of sweat, of him, clung faintly to my skin. I faced away from Eli, curling one arm under the pillow, the other resting along the curve of my waist. The lace of the panties had dried slightly now, cooling against me.

I closed my eyes but I didn't sleep. I only listened to the quiet of our room, to the sound of his breath, and to the feeling of my own body, full and slow and completely changed.

I didn't look back toward the door.

Eli's POV

The light was already coming through the blinds when I opened my eyes. It was weak light, early, angled low across the sheets. I hadn't meant to fall asleep. I had stayed awake for hours after I heard her breathing change in

the other room, after the couch creaked more. I told myself I'd wait until I was sure. I must've drifted off.

I turned onto my side. Talia was beside me.

She was on her stomach, one leg drawn up, her face turned away. The blanket had slipped down around her waist. Her hoody was bunched near her ribs and I could see the curve of her lower back above where her panties should have been, but they weren't on her now. She'd still been dressed when I left her on the couch.

I sat up slowly, careful not to wake her. I pulled on a T-shirt from the floor and walked barefoot down the hall.

The couch was messy, blanket half-off, one of the cushions sunken lower than the others. Darren's shorts were on the armrest. No sign of his shirt. A pillow lay on the floor where it must've fallen during the night. Looking at it, I caught sight of a strap of her bra, kicked under the couch. Darren was sprawled out over the cushions, his face crushed into the pillow that had been between Talia's legs, sleeping deeply.

I crossed to the kitchen. The counter held two glasses, one nearly empty, the other full and untouched. Lipstick on one, a faint smudge on the rim. The wine bottle was open but recorked, sitting askew like it had been done in a hurry.

I went back down the hallway. The bathroom light was off, the door slightly ajar. I stepped inside and saw them instantly. Her panties were on the edge of the hamper, not folded, not set down gently, just left there, one side dangling off the side like it had been dropped without thought. They appeared wet.

I stood in the bathroom for a full minute, staring into the hamper like it would offer an explanation. My hand was on the doorframe, the cool wood steady beneath my palm. My stomach felt hollow, but not from hunger. Not from anger either. I didn't know what I felt.

But I couldn't stop thinking about what I hadn't seen. And the fact that she'd come back to bed after, quietly and soft, curling beside me like nothing had happened.

I made coffee and went out on the balcony to look out over the waking city. The question I had to contemplate was, would I confront Talia about what I found? Would I confront Darren?

Or, the evil thought gripped me and wouldn't let me go, would I pretend I noticed nothing, and see what happens the next night?

The Time My Girlfriend Went Upstairs at a Party

I knew maybe two of the people in our living room, and barely even them. Cass had filled the place like she always did when she was in a hosting mood, cheap string lights, mismatched chairs dragged in from the patio, a Bluetooth speaker on the counter, and a big plastic bowl of liquor punch she called “nurse fuel.” I brought and tried to stay out of the way, which was usually the unspoken arrangement. She handled the people, I made sure no one spilled on the carpet.

The first time I noticed him, he wasn’t doing anything loud, just standing in the kitchen entryway, talking to one of the girls from Cass’s program, a red cup in hand, smiling at whatever she said like he already knew where the conversation was headed. Black guy, probably a couple years older than me, built like someone who played a sport but didn’t need to talk about it. Calm and smooth, something about how comfortable he was in his own body made the rest of us look like we were still waiting for permission to exist.

Cass brought him over with two drinks. “Trey, this is Jared,” she said, touching my arm like I’d somehow wandered off. “Jared, this is Trey. He’s in that kinesiology elective I was telling you about.”

I shook his hand, warm grip, relaxed of course. “Hey,” I said.

He gave a slight nod, an easy smile. “Appreciate you guys having us over. Good energy in here.”

Cass beamed at that like the party had just passed some invisible test. She leaned in and said something else to him as I stepped back to the fridge. I wasn’t needed for the rest of that conversation.

There was music and people laughing, a couple girls dancing near the window like it was a bigger room than it was. Someone from her class had brought two bottles of wine and no corkscrew. Trey pulled one from his back pocket, said it was a habit. Everyone laughed.

Cass was bouncing between clusters of people, topping off drinks, making sure no one felt left out. She was wearing the silver dress with the

little bows at the shoulders, the one she said made her feel “hostessy,” and it showed more leg than she usually let outside the bedroom. She wasn’t trying to be flirtatious. She just lit up when she had a full room to orchestrate. And she looked good doing it.

I remained at the edge of it all, watching her pass him another drink before it was empty. I told myself it was just her being polite.

She perched on the arm of the couch next to him as the group around them laughed at something he said, her legs crossed and swaying gently. She looked happy and relaxed.

And when she touched his shoulder, just lightly, just for emphasis, and didn’t even glance in my direction.

I told myself it was nothing.

The way her hand stayed there, though, curled lightly into his shoulder while she laughed, that was just Cass being animated. She touched people when she talked. It didn’t mean anything. He was the one leaning in, grinning wider every time she said something clever, his eyes never drifting far from her mouth.

I stood by the counter sipping a drink I didn’t even want, pretending to be part of it all. Every now and then I’d catch someone’s eye and nod like I was following the story. But I was really just watching her legs, watching the hem of that dress creep higher each time she shifted her weight. Trey didn’t seem to be trying anything. He wasn’t all over her. But he kept her close.

By ten-thirty, people had started trickling out. One of the girls had an early shift, another was designated driver. Cass hugged them all at the door, thanked them for coming, promised to do it again soon. I stacked a few empties and brought them to the sink. When I turned back, there were only three people left, then after a few more minutes, it was just Trey, Cass, and me.

She didn’t act like anything had changed, though. She plopped down on the couch again beside Trey, tucking her bare legs under her and flashing me a smile like we were just winding down, like it wasn’t strange that I was across the room and she was curled up next to him like it was his apartment now too. She was animated with him discussing the ins and outs of everybody who was there.

She handed him her drink without asking. He took it with no hesitation, took a sip, made a face, and said, “You went easy on the rum this time.”

She laughed. "I'm pacing myself."

"That what you call this?" he teased, his voice low. "I though you were getting bolder."

Cass leaned back resting against the cushion now. "Oh really?" She had fun challenge in her eyes.

"Definitely," he said. "You were way more shy earlier."

Her smile twitched. "Was not."

"You were hiding behind your boyfriend."

At that, she glanced at me for a second, but long enough to make it clear they were talking about me. I gave a little smile, tight and uncertain, but I didn't move. I didn't speak.

"Maybe I'm just getting comfortable now," she said. "Ever think of that?"

"I can tell." He patted his leg. "Come here then if you're so comfortable."

It was a joke. It had to be. But she looked at him a moment, grinned, then swung her legs across his lap like it was nothing. Not fully seated, not straddling, but certainly perching. Half a joke, half a dare.

He didn't look at me and neither did she. It was like I wasn't even there. He said something quiet to her and she laughed, then swatted his arm and let her hand rest there again, her wrist pressed against his chest. She was still smiling but now she was flushed in her cheeks.

I watched her settle more into him, watched her shift her hips to get more comfortable on him. Her knee brushed his and she didn't fix her dress.

She didn't look my way and I didn't stop it. I told myself not to read into it, that it was just part of her playful side, the same way she'd joke with friends or tease her classmates when they crammed for finals. But that wasn't what this was, and I knew it the moment he let his arm fall behind her waist.

It wasn't possessive. That would've been easier to react to. It was relaxed, casual, like his hand had landed there because that's where it fell. She didn't flinch. She didn't even pause. She leaned back, shoulder against his chest, like they were deep into some conversation that required that kind of closeness.

The music was loud enough still I didn't hear anything. I remained in the armchair by the window trying to look like I wasn't paying attention, like this was all still normal. I told myself if she crossed a line, I'd do

something. If he did anything obvious, I'd say something. But everything happening was right on that edge, each touch small enough to deny, each moment soft enough to pretend it was still innocent.

They kept talking in low voices, smiling in that quiet, locked-in way people do when they've tuned the rest of the room out, laughing privately, murmuring jokes. She shifted her weight again, drawing her knees up beside her on the couch, which only pressed her deeper into his lap.

"You're not uncomfortable, are you?" he asked, grinning suspiciously.

She shook her head, almost laughing. "No, why?" she said equally suspiciously.

"Just making sure. You're in my space now I treat my guests right."

She rolled her eyes. "Please. You're the one taking up half the couch."

"That's because you're sitting on me."

"You wanted me to."

"You didn't have to do it."

Cass bit her lip and gave him a look that was half playful, half unreadable. Then she rested her hand on his thigh just above his knee, and left it there while she turned her head toward him to keep talking.

I felt like I was sinking into the chair. I couldn't get a full breath. Every time I thought about standing up, saying something, asking her to come sit next to me instead, I imagined how that would sound. Needy. Controlling. Insecure. I didn't want to be that guy, the guy who makes things weird just because his girlfriend's being friendly.

But this wasn't just friendly. I watched her fingers absently tap against his leg as they talked, she impatient, her bare shoulder brushing against his chest, her laugh coming softer now. She was sitting in his lap and it wasn't a joke anymore.

Trey's hand moved lower on her back easing into place, both of them getting more comfortable. And still, I sat there.

She didn't ask me with her eyes. She didn't check in. She just remained where she was, her body slowly molding into his like this was what the night had been leading toward all along.

I told myself it wasn't far enough to matter. But it was already too far to undo. The worst part was how normal it still looked. That's what kept me frozen: there was no scene to interrupt, no moment that could be called out without sounding insecure. She wasn't climbing on top of him. He wasn't pulling her dress off. It was just two people, two friends sitting close,

laughing softly, talking like everyone else had just stepped into another room.

But I knew that wasn't true. The party had ended twenty minutes ago. The room was quiet except for the music and the occasional rattle of ice shifting in a glass. And she was still on his lap.

Trey's hand slid lower, tracing around her waist now, moving along the side of her dress. His fingers weren't grabbing, they weren't groping, but they were there. Cass didn't say anything. She kept her eyes on him and smiled whenever he spoke, watched his mouth, darted her gaze from eye to eye.

I thought about saying her name, just that, nothing aggressive, just enough to pull her attention back to me. But even the idea of interrupting felt like stepping off a ledge.

She leaned forward, her hand on his chest now as she laughed at something he whispered. The movement pressed her body tighter to his. I could see the curve of her hip against his thigh, the edge of her dress caught against the seam of his jeans. It was all small things, friction, weight, her letting herself settle more.

She glanced at me, just a flick of the eyes, not checking in, more like checking to see if I was still watching. I was. I didn't look away. She held gaze for a moment, then turned back to him, like that had answered something for her.

Trey's voice dropped lower. I couldn't hear what he said, but her reaction was immediate, another small laugh, one she tried to hold back. She reached for her drink, took a sip, then set it back down without moving from his lap.

Her legs shifted, uncrossing, knees dropping open. I saw the hem of her dress ride higher. She didn't notice, or maybe she did and didn't care.

"You cold baby?" he asked her.

"A little," she said.

"Come closer, then."

She rolled her eyes, but she didn't argue. She adjusted herself on him, inching closer to his chest, her arm curling across his torso now, chin resting near his shoulder.

From where I sat, all I could see was her body and his hands, one resting at the small of her spine, the other now slowly rubbing her thigh.

She let him.

I watched her body respond, not dramatically, but in those small, steady shifts, the way her spine arched, the way her fingers curled against his shirt, the way her legs opened just a bit wider when his thumb brushed higher along her inner thigh.

She wasn't pulling away. She wasn't stopping anything. And I was still pretending not to notice.

He touched her knee. I watched it happen, his hand sliding down the length of her thigh, palm open, deliberate in a way that was careful but not shy. His fingertips brushed along the inside curve and settled just above the knee. Nothing that could be called overt, nothing that would get him kicked out of a party. But it was the kind of touch that assumed it was okay.

Cass didn't even twitch. She was still angled into him, half-twisted on his lap, talking softly. Her voice wasn't shaking. If anything, it had gotten steadier. She said something about the playlist, something about how she used to dance to this song in high school. He laughed and she laughed with him. The sound of it didn't match the heat gathering in her skin.

His hand moved again, this time along the outside of her thigh, then back across the top, brushing the edge of her dress where the hem clung tight to her. She pulled her legs up, adjusting how she sat, and in doing so she pressed herself more completely into him. Her thighs came together, tucking under her, but she didn't shift away. She looked at him, cheeks warm, mouth slightly open like she was trying not to smile.

He reached up and touched her shoulder. "You keep letting this fall," he said, thumb nudging the little bow at the top of her dress strap. "You coming onto me, girl?"

She chuckled. "I guess I just tied it bad," she said quietly.

"You sure you want it tied at all?"

"Shut up," she laughed lightly and she pinched his lips closed, but left her hand cupping his jaw, her fingers lightly on his lips.

She looked down at her drink. Her hand adjusted the fabric, not pulling it up, not fixing it, just grazing the edge where her skin had started to show too much. She looked at me again for a second, but long enough for me to register the flush in her cheeks and the way her hair had started to fall across her face.

I didn't say a word.

Trey leaned in a little, his lips close to her ear, and whispered something more. She bit the corner of her lip, the same way she did when she was

trying to suppress a real reaction. She planted her hand on his chest again, not to push him back, but to curl her fingers in his shirt

He let the strap slip farther. She watched it fall. Then she reached up and touched it herself, hesitating with her fingers at the loose bow. Trey didn't move. He let her decide. Her eyes flicked to mine again, and she paused like she was giving me the chance to say something, to shake my head, to do anything.

But I didn't.

Her hand dropped back to her lap, and the strap slid off her shoulder and hung loose.

Her skin caught the light in a way that made everything else in the room feel artificial, like the party lights and the furniture and even the music had all faded into background decoration. It was like she was under a stage spotlight. The strap hung down her arm, loose now, the round of her shoulder bare and newly unfamiliar. She remained rocking in his lap with her dress slipping lower, her thighs still tucked beside him, her hand resting gently on his chest.

Trey didn't take more than what she gave, but he didn't pretend not to see it either. His eyes moved slowly over her body, not groping or wide with surprise, but taking her in like he was finally seeing what he had been working toward. His hand returned to her side, smoothing along the fabric bunched at her waist, and then to the middle of her back where it settled firmly. The moment stretched in that way tension does when no one breaks the silence, when all three of us knew exactly what had changed and none of us moved to stop it.

Cass reached up and touched the other strap. She didn't untie it but her fingers played with it, looped it once around, then let it go. She looked at me again, and this time the look held longer, as if some small part of her was still taking the temperature. She wasn't asking for permission, but she wasn't pretending I didn't exist either. Her face was pink, her eyes wide and alert, but there was no apology in her expression, only breathless uncertainty and something behind it that looked like the early edge of want.

I waited for her to cover up. I waited for her to laugh, to play the joke, to pull the strap back up and make a crack about how warm the apartment had gotten. She didn't. She just turned back toward Trey and leaned into him more, pressed her cheek against his jaw, her arm now fully across his chest.

He spoke again, low in her ear, and this time I saw her smile, not because it was funny, but because whatever he said had slipped past all the usual defenses. Her body moved against his, her thigh shifting, her shoulder rising as she adjusted herself. She was moving closer.

Trey let his fingers trail up from her hip to the side of her chest, pausing just beneath the fabric, letting them rest there without pressure. Her breath hitched. She looked down at his hand, then back at his face, and said nothing, but she playfully pursed her lips and widened her eyes.

Her hand moved first. She reached for his wrist, not to stop him, but to hold it, like she wanted to feel the weight of it against her. The second strap slipped down.

Her dress fell down slowly, caught at first on the shape of her chest, before surrendering to gravity in small, revealing slips until the fabric gathered at her waist. Her hands remained in her lap, not covering herself, not reaching for the straps. She sat more upright in his lap, bare from the waist up, her breath quick and shallow but steady enough to make it clear this wasn't some accident she planned to undo. He must have untied it from behind her shoulder, like he did the first strap as well. She gave him a look of disappointment, before she stuck her tongue out at him.

I couldn't move. My chest was tight with it. I was sitting no more than six feet away, and I couldn't bring myself to speak. I wasn't even sure what I would've said if I had. There was no moment to interrupt, no sharp line that had been crossed, only the slow, seamless transition from flirtation into exposure, the kind that had slipped so naturally into place that calling it out would've made it feel real in a way none of us seemed ready to acknowledge out loud.

Trey looked at her like he had all the time in the world. He didn't rush to touch her. He didn't grope or paw her. He just looked with the kind of calm satisfaction that comes from knowing you've been invited to. His hand moved eventually, not to cup her breast, but to trace around it, the back of his fingers skimming the curve of her skin at the side of her breast like he was learning its temperature.

Cass's eyes fluttered but only for a moment. She wasn't looking at either of us now, she was focused inward, on sensation, on breath, on holding herself still while his fingers circled slowly around. Her mouth parted and she swallowed. She didn't try to say anything, because there was nothing

left to say. She had let him undress her, and now she was letting him explore her.

His hand moved closer, and when he brushed it across her nipple, her shoulders tensed just slightly, and pulled up. A quiet sound left her lips, not loud enough to be called a moan, but audible enough that I felt it like a pulse in my neck. Her hips shifted forward as if her whole body had taken that single touch inside. She leaned into him more fully now, one arm wrapped around the back of his neck, the other still resting in her lap.

Trey whispered something to her again. The tone was clear and gentle, coaxing and intimate. Cass gave a small nod, eyes half-lidded now. She reached up, touched his jaw, and tilted her head into the space where his mouth waited. When she kissed him, it wasn't fast or aggressive. It was slow and open-mouthed. She met it like she'd been waiting to find out how it would feel to kiss him like this, skin against skin, nothing between them anymore.

She kissed him like it was something they'd already done in her mind, something already overdue. There was no hesitation in the way her lips moved with his, no flinch when his hand returned to her breast, this time cupping it fully, his thumb tracing slow circles that made her hips stir. Her bare skin shifted against his shirt with every breath, the warmth between them turning visible now in the way she pressed her chest into his palm.

The music pounded and I couldn't stop watching. Every time I thought I would say something, stand, move, interrupt, the moment changed just enough to keep me stuck in my place. They weren't screwing on the couch. It was nothing loud or explicit. It was just two people pressed tightly together, kissing, touching, and a third, me, frozen in the corner, silently pretending it was all still reversible.

I felt encased in cement. My face felt like it had been plastered. Her hand slid across his stomach, curious, as though feeling the shape of him through his shirt. She slouched lower, her fingers resting just above his belt. His hand stayed on her chest while his mouth drifted from her mouth to her neck, then lower, pressing kisses along the slope of her shoulder and down to the edge of where her dress still clung around her ribs.

Cass tilted her head back, her eyes closed, and her lips parted. I watched her body respond to him with soft, involuntary shifts, her spine arching, her thighs flexing. Her skin flushed pink across her chest, and when he took her nipple into his mouth, she gasped.

It was sharp and real, one pure sound, the kind she makes when something catches her off guard, something intimate. The worse it got, the more I stiffened with paralysis. It was the music, it was beating so incessantly, the lights were dim, my mind swirled. It felt like I was the one who didn't belong.

She gripped the back of his head, holding him there, her fingers twisting into his hair as he sucked on her gently, one then the other. Her other hand, still resting on his belt, tugged slightly at the waist now, like she wanted him closer and didn't care I was right there, or forgot.

Trey pulled back just enough to look at her. "You're shaking baby," he murmured.

Cass gave a quiet, breathy laugh and touched her lips to his again. "You shouldn't, you know," she whispered.

"You good?"

She nodded, breathing hard. "Yeah. It's just . . ."

He waited.

"It feels so good," she breathed and she hid her face in his neck.

Trey's smile was soft and sure. He reached down then, one hand sliding between her thighs. She didn't stop him. She didn't even hesitate. She lifted her hips as he adjusted the hem of her dress, then eased it higher, exposing the white cotton of her panties. His fingers grazed the inside of her thigh, all of it slow and gentle, all of it by tiny increments.

I felt like I shouldn't watch. It felt like I couldn't tell if this was right for a girlfriend or not. My mind was like a tornado.

She leaned forward, forehead to his. He touched her down there, through the fabric. She gasped, softer this time, and her legs parted for him. Her hand stayed on his belt, her fingers curled and her nails scratched at his denim.

The sound she made when he touched her on the centre of her panties wasn't loud, but it hollowed something out in me. Her breath caught in her throat, her hips curled into his hand, and I saw her lose total track of where she was. Her focus narrowed completely to the feel of his fingers pressing through the thin fabric between her legs. Her head dropped, hair fell over her face, her shoulders curled in like she was trying to stay inside the sensation.

Trey didn't look at me. He had her attention, all of it, and he knew it. His hand moved slowly, his thumb dragging in slow, teasing strokes that made

her legs part even wider around his thigh, her back arching just enough to push her closer. She whispered his name, and the way it left her mouth, she'd given up trying to resist him in any way.

He kissed her again, one hand still working between her legs, the other sliding around to the small of her back. I could see her thighs trembling now. Her breath came faster, uneven, her hand gripping his shoulder like it was the only thing tethering her to the couch.

"I have to feel you," he said quietly.

She only nodded.

He slipped his fingers beneath the edge of her tight lace panties, slow enough that I could see the shape of them stretch before they gave way. Her whole body went still for a moment. She exhaled hard through her nose, then let out a low sound as his fingers touched her bare.

Her thighs opened wider on instinct.

I watched his hand move beneath the fabric rhythmically, his wrist turning as he found her, pressed her, circled her, slid inside her. Cass grabbed his forearm, her eyes squeezed shut, and her mouth dropped open as she tried to breathe through the building pressure.

I could see the change hit her face, her eyebrows drawing in, her chest tightening, her legs going rigid, then trembling again as her body pulsed around him. Her hand covered her mouth, muffling the quiet gasp that escaped her. She rode it out in silence, body pressed into him, her head buried against his neck.

He held her through it, murmuring things I couldn't hear, his hand slowing only after her grip on him began to loosen.

She hung draped across his lap, panting softly against his shoulder, one arm wrapped around the back of his neck, the other falling slack at her side.

When she pulled back, her eyes were glassy, lips parted, face flushed.

He kissed her again, soft and deep.

She didn't say anything and she didn't look at me. She only sat up straighter, pushed the straps of her panties down over her hips, and slid them off completely.

She stepped out of them one leg at a time, slow and steadily, folding the damp white cotton into her palm like she'd forgotten I was anywhere in the room, or maybe she remembered and had decided it didn't matter. She didn't hand them to him or toss them aside. She just set them on the arm of the couch, and settled back into his lap without a word.

I was already dead inside. I felt like a ghost. I felt like furniture, stiff, wooden and cold. My heart may have pounded, but my mind was slowing to nothing. I couldn't feel my legs or arms. I tried to open my mouth as though to say something, and couldn't get it to obey.

Her body was bare from the waist down now, the dress bunched high at her middle, barely covering her, and she was bare beneath that, too. Her skin was flushed, the insides of her thighs streaked with the glossy sheen of what he'd drawn out of her. Trey didn't move. He just calmly considered her like he was working on art, trying to commit to memory the way she looked in that exact moment, skin warm, chest rising, lips parted, her knees drawn wide as she straddled his thigh.

When he reached for his jeans, it was quiet and methodical. He unbuttoned them without looking down, pulling the zipper open while Cass watched, her hands now resting at the tops of her own thighs. She didn't move to help him but she calmly waited, her breath shallow, her eyes locked on to what he was about to show her.

He shifted under her and freed himself and I saw her eyes widen.

Even from where I sat, I could see it, thick, heavy, too large for any comfortable first glance. Her mouth parted and she gave a soft, nervous laugh, almost embarrassed by her own reaction to the size of it.

"Jesus," she whispered and she bit her lip.

Trey smiled but didn't say anything. His hand wrapped loosely around the base and he gave himself a slow stroke like he wanted her to see the full weight of it before inviting her to do anything.

I swallowed hard. I was afraid my heart would collapse. Trey lifted his eyes to mine, he grinned, and he gestured with his finger to his lips for me to say nothing. I was never more confused. I felt my soul leave my body and float up to the ceiling. What do I do? What do I do? screamed a voice over and over, me not even realizing that was me.

She reached out cautiously, fingers brushing his length at first like she wasn't sure where to begin. When she wrapped her hand around it, I saw the difference in scale, the way her grip couldn't close fully, how her thumb came nowhere near her fingers on the other side.

She looked up at him and dropped her mouth wide open, gave him her big shocked eyes. .

"Are you sure?" she murmured.

His voice was low, soft. "I want you to try."

Cass hesitated then she nodded. Her hand began to move, slow and carefully over him. Her eyes when from his member to his face as she stroked him, searching for the right pressure, the right pace. When he sighed, she adjusted, her other hand bracing against his leg as she leaned forward.

Her hair slid off her shoulder. She kissed the tip.

He groaned under his breath.

She kissed it again, lower this time, then opened her mouth and took him in, just the head, her lips stretched wide. She pulled back, caught her breath, then tried again, deeper this time, slower and with both hands now wrapped around the base as she worked her way farther down his length.

She didn't glance at me. I wasn't there.

She took her time with him. Her movements weren't rushed or clumsy, but they weren't hesitant either. She was teaching herself what he liked by feel alone. Her lips glided along his length in slow, wet passes, and each time she came up for air, she paused only long enough to grip him tighter, to swirl her tongue around the head, to ease back down with more of him than before. It wasn't just skill, it was intent. She wanted to please him, to feel him, to learn the shape of his body with her mouth.

His hand rested on the back of her head, guiding her, his fingers moving through her hair as if in rhythm with the slow pace she'd set. He watched her the entire time, quiet, focused, mouth slack in awe. Every now and then he murmured something, small words of encouragement, barely audible praise that made her hum around him and close her eyes harder, like it meant something to hear it from him.

I sat completely frozen across the room, watching the woman I thought I loved crouch between another man's legs, moaning softly as she pulled him deeper into her mouth with every stroke. Her bare thighs were parted, knees sinking into the couch cushion. Her dress had fallen behind her, forgotten now. Her back arched when she shifted, the muscles along her spine moving like waves as she adjusted her angle to take more of him in her mouth.

Trey exhaled through his teeth, his voice low and strained. "You're so fucking good at this, baby," and he chuckled. He looked up at me, and repeated himself, "She is so fucking good at it, you know what I mean?" He caressed her face, massaged her hair, and nodded at me.

I felt like I was made of paper.

She didn't answer him. She couldn't. Her lips were stretched wide, cheeks hollowing as she worked him with a rhythm that was almost hypnotic, up, down, twist, repeat. The wet sounds filled the room on top of the music. Her hand squeezed at the base while her tongue teased the underside. She was completely absorbed in the act.

At one point she pulled back, her lips shiny, breath catching, and she looked up at him.

"Too much?" she asked, a real question, innocence on her face.

He shook her head. "No., just right. You like it?"

Her eyes stayed on his. "Yeah," she said and she grinned coyly.

He smiled back, slow and warm. "Then don't stop, baby."

She didn't. She went back down on him with more focus, more energy, her strokes longer now, smoother, now with the kind of confidence that came from seeing the effect she was having on him. He moaned again, deeper this time, and his hips started to move, meeting her mouth as she bobbed over him.

She let him guide her. She let him use her mouth.

When he finally pulled her off, his hand cupping her cheek, she looked dazed, her breathing ragged, a string of spit still connecting them.

Trey wiped her mouth with his thumb, then leaned in and kissed her. Her lips were wet, her body flushed, and when he pulled her onto his lap, she straddled him like there was nowhere else she was supposed to be.

Her knees settled to either side of his hips as if she'd done it before. The kiss deepened slower, more drawn out than the first, her hands sliding to the back of his neck, fingers curling against the base of his skull. Her chest pressed into his, her breathing fast and shallow, her thighs tightening around him as she rocked forward.

Trey's hands moved along her naked sides, palms smoothing over her bare hips, the fabric of her dress still bunched behind her like an afterthought. He shifted beneath her and she lifted just enough for him to push his jeans down further. His erection rested against her, slick and hard between them. She looked down between their bodies and watched it slide against her belly, her hand reaching to guide him.

She gripped him with something close to awe, or a curious still, but certainly no longer shy. She stroked him once, twice, then positioned the head against herself. Her mouth parted as she shifted her weight forward in his lap.

I lost my breath. My blood drained from my head.

The first moment of contact stopped her. She froze, jaw clenched, and she pressed her forehead to his.

“You want it?” he asked again, quiet and close.

She nodded quickly. “Yeah,” she seemed to cry. “It’s just so big,” she whispered loud enough for me to hear. She darted a glance over her shoulder at me. I turned to ice.

He smiled and ran his hands slowly up her undulating back, his voice low and calm. “Just take your time. Go slow.”

Cass inhaled through her nose, then lowered her hips by degrees, every inch a negotiation with her body. Her mouth opened wider as he entered her, her fingers pressing into his shoulders, the tension in her legs tightening from resistance to embrace. She was breathing fast now, her eyes squeezing shut.

I watched her body shift and descend, watched her take him deeper with each soft exhale, until finally her hips settled all the way down on him and her thighs met his. Her entire posture trembled from the effort of taking him all the way in.

He was inside her, I could see it from behind her back. He held her there, hands steady on her hips, letting her adjust to it. Her breath caught again and again. She looked down at him, stunned, not by guilt or shame, but by the reality of what her body had just done. She had taken another man inside her, a much bigger man.

Trey kissed her neck, her shoulder, the edge of her jaw. He whispered something that made her smile through the tension.

Then she started to move. Her hips rolled slowly at first, short tight circles as she learned his rhythm, his shape. Her hands flattened against his chest, centering herself. Her moans were quiet, nearly voiceless, just vibrations in her throat. But I heard all of them. Every shift of her hips was smoother now, bolder.

She looked down at his face and kissed him again, deeper, sucking off his tongue in her mouth, her body beginning to rock with real momentum.

She rode him with the kind of focus I had never seen in her before, slow and certain, her hips rolling with purpose, not for his pleasure or mine, but something entirely her own. Her breathing stayed high and shallow, her thighs flexing with every motion. The way her hands moved over his chest

told me she was no longer thinking about what she was doing, only how it felt.

Trey let her move the way she wanted. He didn't rush her, didn't grab her or steer. His hands remained on her hips, his thumbs tracing the curve of her waist as she built her own pace. Every time her hips came down, he met her with just enough lift to keep her grounded in the motion. She wasn't bouncing, she was grinding, deep, slow, and wet, full with him, stuffed by him.

The sound of it filled the room. Her body meeting his with the faint slap of skin. Her breath exhaled through parted lips, then gasped when he lifted his hips more firmly into her. The couch creaked beneath them, a quiet, steady rhythm matched by the movement of her knees against the cushion.

Her head tilted back. Her hands moved to her own body now, one trailing across her chest, fingertips grazing the top of her breast, then circling one nipple until she shivered from the touch. Her other hand braced behind her, palm flat against his thigh, steadying her as she leaned back and changed the angle of her hips. Trey groaned low, and she moaned in response, her body settling deeper over him.

I didn't realize I was gripping the arm of my chair until my knuckles began to ache.

Her eyes opened briefly, glossy with heat and she smiled at him.

She leaned forward again, hands on his chest, and kissed him hard and frantic. Her body was working now with more rhythm, thighs pumping, the sound of her wetness undeniable. He slid a hand between them, his fingers finding her again, rubbing circles at the top of where they were joined. She gasped into his mouth.

"Oh God," she whispered, pulling back just enough to breathe.

"You gonna come again baby?" he asked.

She nodded, her movements stuttering as the tension in her thighs returned. Her fingers clawed at his shoulders and her rhythm started to unravel with less control and more need. She ground her hips hard into him now, chasing the edge with no care for how it looked or how it sounded. I could see it all from behind her, how wet everything was.

When it hit her, she collapsed forward, arms wrapped around his neck, body quivering as her voice caught in her throat. She buried her face in his shoulder, but her hips didn't stop moving, even as her moans turned to broken sighs and soft, whimpering gasps.

Trey held her tightly, kissing her neck, whispering again. She clung to him like she didn't want to come down from it.

And still she was moving. Even as her body trembled from the release, she didn't pull away. If anything, she sank deeper into him, grinding in slow, lingering circles. Her hands moved over his chest with new urgency, not clumsy or desperate anymore, but charged now with something more than curiosity, like having him inside her had unlocked a different kind of hunger. Her lips found his again, mouth open and searching, and he kissed her like he was just beginning.

Trey's hands were firmer now, gripping her hips with purpose, guiding her into a rhythm that matched his slow thrusts from beneath. He rocked up into her, deep and steady, and I watched her entire body lift and drop with his motion, her back arching as she adjusted to take him again and again. The wet sound of them filled the space between the creaking couch and her ragged breaths. He was ragdolling her.

She looked down, breathless, her face flushed and shining with sweat, her hair falling into her eyes as she braced her hands against his stomach. She was riding him now with dragging strokes that had her moaning softly each time he bottomed out.

"God, you feel so good," she murmured.

Trey grinned. "You're tight baby."

Cass bit her lip, her eyes fluttering closed as she moved harder, deeper. Her hands slid up his chest and locked behind his neck. She pulled him closer and whispered something into his ear, something I couldn't make out, but that made him groan and grab her ass, pulling her down onto him with more force now. Their bodies met with a sharper slap of skin, louder now, faster.

I could see everything, the muscles in her back, the way her hips twisted, the sheen along her thighs, the way her mouth dropped open as her body chased another climax. She rode him without apology, fully open, completely taken, and the more she gave herself over to it, the more beautiful she looked.

Her breath caught again, and her rhythm faltered. He knew.

His hand found her again, fingers between her legs, pressing, stroking, working her toward another release as his other arm wrapped around her waist. She gripped his shoulders, forehead pressed to his, and whispered his name like a plea.

She came hard, this time louder, messier, the kind of orgasm that emptied her lungs and curled her body tight to his. Her thighs shook. Her arms tightened. Her hips kept moving.

He was close now and she could feel it.

She felt him swelling inside her. I could see it in the way her rhythm changed, her hips slowing just enough to feel every inch of the new stretch, her movements syncing to the pulsing tension in his body as he neared the edge. Her face hovered just above his, lips parted, breath hot against his cheek, and her eyes stayed open now, watching him. She knew he was about to finish. She wanted him to. She adjusted her position to take him even deeper.

Trey gripped her hips harder this time, fingers digging into her skin as he thrust up into her with short, heavy movements. The calm confidence he'd held all night gave way to something more primal now, his voice low and ragged in her ear. She whispered back, words I couldn't hear, but the sound of them made him groan like she'd said exactly what he needed.

He lifted her, then slammed her back down onto him with a rhythm that grew faster and rougher. She gasped at the sudden force but didn't resist it. Her hands flattened against his chest and she braced herself as he used her body now with clear intent. She held herself open for him, her thighs stretched wide, her spine arching, her moans turning into short, broken sounds. She was being taken.

Trey's head fell back, his grip unrelenting, and I saw his body jerk once, twice.

He was coming inside her.

Her body tightened in response, hips pressing down to keep him deep, her breath catching as she felt the warmth flood into her. She didn't pull off, she remained still, trembling, letting him finish inside her, letting him empty everything into her without a word.

The room fell silent except for their breathing. The tension that had been stretching for what felt like hours finally broke, not with a crash, but with a slow settling. Cass slumped forward, chest to his, arms limp around his neck. Trey's hands softened at her sides, no longer guiding her, just holding her.

Neither of them spoke. She kissed his neck once, then let her forehead rest against his shoulder.

I sat in the same place I'd been since the beginning, unmoving, silent, my jaw clenched so tightly I wasn't sure if I'd be able to speak even if I tried. She had just let another man come inside her, slowly, deeply, completely, and she hadn't looked at me once during the whole thing, not for reassurance, not for permission, not for guilt.

She was still in his lap, his cock still inside her. I could see him run out of her. Her body twitched gently as she re-adjusted, and I saw her shift her hips to take one last deep breath against him before she finally lifted herself. A soft, wet sound followed, and his hands guided her down beside him.

She didn't speak. She moved slowly, carefully, like her legs weren't fully steady under her yet. Trey helped her ease down onto the couch beside him, his arm around her waist while she settled, the hem of her dress still bunched around her hips, exposing everything. Her skin was flushed and marked from where he'd held her, a faint pink line across her thigh where his fingers had gripped her too tightly. She didn't pull the dress down. She didn't reach for her underwear. She leaned against him and exhaled with her eyes closed, her face calm in a way I'd never seen after sex, not even with me.

Trey brushed her hair back and kissed her temple. She didn't flinch. Her hand found his knee and rested there. I could see the tips of his fingers still gliding over the inside of her thigh, slow, absentminded strokes.

I wanted to move, to stand, to make some sound that would remind her I was still there. But I didn't. My body felt like it didn't belong to me. I could feel the sweat drying at my temples, the tension in my chest burning like I'd been holding my breath for hours. I wanted to look away but I couldn't. I wanted to run, but it was like a dream where you can't move.

Trey leaned forward, kissed her neck, then stood. His cock hung heavy and slick as he tucked himself back into his jeans, his movements casual, like everything that had happened was just part of the night. He was shameless, remorseless. He pulled on his shirt without hurry and stretched, glancing around the room like he was getting ready to head out after a good hangout. Cass watched him with a soft, dazed smile. She hadn't moved to cover herself. She sat there naked, hair a mess, thighs wet with it, and didn't seem to care that I could see everything.

Trey grabbed his hoodie from the floor, slung it over his shoulder, and turned to look at me as though for the first time all night.

"You good?" he asked. There was no sarcasm. Just calm, a real question.

I didn't answer. I wasn't sure I could. What would I say?

He nodded like that was enough.

"She's a special one," he said, voice quiet. "But you already know that."

He looked back at her one more time. She was watching him now, still half lying on the couch, her fingers grazing the mark he'd left on her thigh.

"Get some rest," he said to her. Then he walked to the door and let himself out.

The latch clicked behind him. The hallway light spilled in for a moment, then vanished.

The silence after he left was total.

Eventually, she stood. She picked up her panties from the edge of the couch, looked at them for a moment, then carried them with her toward the bathroom. Her walk was slow, her legs shaky.

She closed the door behind her without a word. Water started running a moment later.

I stayed in the chair, not because I didn't want to move, but because I couldn't. The room had gone still, emptied of everything except the warmth left behind by what had happened, her body, his hands, the sounds they made together. There were pillows on the floor, a half-drunk glass of whiskey on the table, her panties folded in her hand as she'd walked to the bathroom like it was just part of cleaning up after a party.

I listened to the water run. The soft hiss of it behind the door was the only sound now, and it made the rest of the apartment feel hollow. I could picture her in there, standing under the stream, rinsing sweat and cum and whatever else from her thighs, her back against the tile. Maybe she was leaning on the wall. Maybe she wasn't thinking about me at all.

I stood finally and walked toward the couch. Her dress was still there, wrinkled and twisted, holding the shape of her body where it had been pulled tight across her hips. I touched the fabric but didn't pick it up. I saw a faint smear across the cushion, a mix of her and him, and I froze again, staring at it like if I looked long enough it might vanish. It didn't.

I crossed the room to the sink and rinsed my glass. My heart was still pounding.

The bathroom door opened. She stepped out wearing her robe. Her hair was damp, curling at the ends. She didn't look surprised to see me standing there.

She walked to the couch and sat again, pulling her legs up underneath her, robe tied loose, the skin of her thigh visible through the gap in the fabric. She stared at her hands for a while and then at the floor.

After a moment she looked up.

“We can’t talk about it, right?” she said. Her voice wasn’t cold, it was just quiet and steady.

I didn’t answer.

She nodded slowly to herself. She stood again, walked past me down the hall toward the bedroom, and left the light on behind her. I remained where I was.

The place still held everything. Her moans. His voice. The rhythm of her body above him. The look on her face when she came. But already it was drifting into the ether like it didn’t happen.

I turned off the music. The silence after was total. I picked up the glasses, closed the window, folded the blanket and laid it over the back of the couch, picked up the spilled cushions. I didn’t clean the spot where she’d sat. I didn’t touch that cushion. I wasn’t sure if I should or could.

I thought about what she’d rinsed off under the water, how long she’d stood there, whether she’d touched herself again, or just watched his cum slide down her leg and disappear into the drain.

The bedroom was dark except for the faint glow from her phone charging on the nightstand. She was already under the sheets, curled on her side, facing away from my side of the bed. Her hair was spread across the pillow, her bare shoulder rising with each breath. She didn’t say anything when I stepped in and she didn’t look at me.

I sat on the edge of the mattress. After a while, she spoke, barely louder than a whisper. “So seriously, we can’t talk about it, okay? He was my ex.”

I sat on the edge of the bed with my face in my hands contemplating the whole thing all over again from that completely new angle. At least it made more sense, the way she took to him, the way she knew what he liked, there was that. And my logical mind got involved, too: I knew she had an ex. I knew the sex was apparently good, if the relationship was not. I knew, now, she had sex with that man a lot before. So it wasn’t new, it was just a matter of timing, technically.

I was about to respond to her over my shoulder when she added, “Even if it happens again?”

Those words held in the air between us like cement. They weren't daring or cruel. They came across as simply honest. It was going to happen again, she was telling me. And we wouldn't talk about it.

I didn't answer. How could I?

I laid back beside her careful not to let our bodies touch. Her breathing remained even. She didn't repeat the question and she didn't press. She let it hang there, unanswered as though she thought I might need some time to consider it.

After a while, when she was now asleep, or pretending to be, I closed my eyes too. The scene played out on the back of my eyelids. Her hand reached across the void between us and found my hand and held it, squeezed it.

I squeezed her back and I wondered about myself until I fell asleep too.

The Time My Girlfriend Visited the Guy Upstairs

The walls and floors were thin enough to hear footsteps. That was the first thing Mason noticed when they moved in to their new apartment. The upstairs tenant, whoever he was, ran every morning, showered with music on, and and watched a lot of football. Mason didn't complain. Noise was part of the charm of century-old apartment buildings, he told Lauren. Real hardwood floors, old doors, windows with iron frames. Lauren smiled and unpacked the mugs.

They kept a soft and quiet life. Mason worked from home, always in sweatpants and a hoodie, fingers constantly moving across his laptop keys, sometimes muttering dialogue to himself. Lauren worked part-time at a boutique two blocks over, liked walking back with a smoothie in hand, her phone in the other, still in her work flats and tan skirt, her hair bouncing. She never spoke until she'd kissed his cheek and dropped her bag on the counter. They had a rhythm and it was a simple one they both settle into and liked well enough.

But he came into it like bad weather. One morning Lauren passed him on the stairs, then again, the next morning, stepping aside to let is large frame pass. She didn't remember seeing him before. He was tall, wide-shouldered, darker-skinned, and always seemed mid-laugh, even without smiling.

Something about him fascinated her. She liked to think she was worldly and cosmopolitan, but she'd never known someone like him, not up close.

The first time she met his eyes, she looked away before hers fully widening. The second time, she returned his disarming smile. She told Mason there was a new guy upstairs. Mason asked if he was loud. Lauren shrugged. "He's just around."

"He watches football I bet."

"Probably. Looks the type, for sure."

She told herself she wasn't thinking about him when she wore her loose white tank with the thin straps and the high-cut jean shorts. It was hot out, after all. Mason was upstairs typing. She passed the man in the entry again,

said hi like she always did, having learned his typical time for coming home. He turned from the mailbox, lifted his brows, and held the door for her. She stepped through and felt her shoulder brush his chest. She looked up, said, “Thanks” with a voice that failed, and didn’t say anything else. But she smiled too long before walking on.

The next time, he spoke this time. His voice was lower than she expected, not booming but firm, and it made her pause at the base of the stairs before answering. Something about the way he looked down at her from above, the angle of it, the heat that seemed to rise off him, she answered slower than she would, her hand on the rail behind her. He asked if she lived downstairs, if her boyfriend was the guy always home on his laptop. She nodded and told him Mason was a writer. He laughed. “I figured. And you?”

“I work nearby,” she said, holding her cards close. She asked his name.

“Caleb,” he said.

When she gave him hers, “Lauren,” he repeated it, not correcting or teasing it, just saying it like he was already knew he’d be using it later. She smiled again and looked down as she stepped past him. He moved aside but far enough. She could feel him still facing her as she climbed the stairs away from him.

In the apartment, Mason was reading what he’d just written, head down, tapping his fingers at the screen like checking it for a pulse. Lauren didn’t speak, so as not to disturb him, and leaned at the sink a moment before heading to the bedroom to change.

Their bedroom window faced the alley. Light came in sideways, bending around the buildings across the lot. Lauren closed the door halfway, kicked off her shoes, and pulled the tank over her head with one arm crossed behind her back. She reached for her shorts, paused, then pushed them down and stepped out, leaving them folded near the dresser. The door creaked. She listened a second, then turned away and changed her underwear, this time into a thinner pair, black and low. Lace. She pulled on a long shirt that barely covered them and padded barefoot to the kitchen.

Mason was still clicking madly away. She slid into the chair beside him, crossed one leg over the other, and watched the screen. He was writing dialogue, something about a dinner scene. She tilted her head, rested her chin on her fist. “That one’s good,” she said after reading a line. He smiled without looking.

She went quiet again and let him work.

Later that night, they watched a show curled together on the couch. She tucked herself into him, and he kissed her forehead when the lights dimmed, rubbing her arm absently while watching the action flick. Lauren's mind wandered, though she control exactly where to.

She had felt the heat of Caleb's body through that brief brush on the stairs, the difference in posture, in space. His size was notable. Her breath had quickened, but only for a moment. It was nothing, really. He had an athletic physique, was all, like he looked after himself, worked out, ate well. Probably cooked well, too, as he had a French accent. She chuckled to herself.

"I bet it's soccer, not football you're hearing," she said to Mason, a wide grin for solving the mystery.

"Huh?"

"Upstairs, when you hear his games. He has an accent."

"You talked to the guy?"

"No," she said, putting her attention back on the show.

The next afternoon, Mason had a Zoom meeting with his editor. She didn't want to be in the background, so she took her smoothie and stepped out onto the common porch. The stairs creaked above. She didn't look until the second footfall, then casually glanced over her shoulder. Caleb was coming down in workout clothes, a towel slung around his neck. His shirt clung to his chest, damp at the chest, and his eyes flicked down to her legs before returning to her face.

"You always drink those ugly green things?" he asked, nodding at her cup, big grin spreading up his face.

"Sometimes," she said. "Depends how bad I feel about myself that day." She shrugged and chuckled at her own joke.

He grinned. "Today must be rough then."

It wasn't French exactly, not Paris French.

She laughed too loud and too fast, then touched her forehead like she was brushing something off. "Guess it was."

He stepped past her and paused at the base of the stairs. "I was going to do a second run later. If I don't melt."

"You always run twice a day?"

"Sometimes I do. It always depends on how bad I feel about myself." He laughed a rich, deep laugh, and saluted her before heading out up the alley.

She felt herself blush, felt her lips parting, but she didn't say anything back. He gave a slight nod, turned, and jogged down the alley, his towel shifting against his back with each step.

She waited until he was at the street before she exhaled. Her thighs pressed together, not out of modesty, but something else, some sort of unresolved energy, it felt like, like an itch behind the skin.

The door behind her creaked. Mason waved his phone, indicating to her his call was done. She smiled at him and went inside. But that evening she showered longer than usual, washing slow, turning the water to warmer settings, eyes closed, losing track of time.

Lauren didn't mind the stairs. They gave her time to reset, to check her phone, or think through whatever she didn't want to bring inside. But lately she lingered, at the base of the stairwell, by the locked mailbox row, or she hesitated just a second after getting the little newspaper she liked, hoping, not planning, of course, to hear the sound of his weight above, the creak of his footfall.

That Thursday, it happened. She had just bent to check the package box when she heard the door above open and close. Caleb descended, gym bag in one hand, earbuds hanging around his neck. He slowed his skip down the steps when he saw her, adjusting his grip, his gaze running a lower like it always did when he alighted upon her. She stood brushing her arm against the metal boxes, and gave him a soft neighborly smile.

"Don't tell me you're finally moving out," he said, glancing at the parcel tucked under her arm.

"Just new shoes," she said. "On sale, of course." She exaggerated the look of pride and laughed.

"Lucky you."

"Lucky me." She laughed, but her breath caught in her throat as he reached forward, brushed a loose thread from the hem of her top near her hip. His fingers didn't graze skin, but she felt them anyway. She didn't back away and she didn't lean in either. Her body locked up between options.

It wasn't anything to do with Mason, she told herself later. It didn't have anything to do with anything, she assured herself. A man can be interesting. A man can be disarming. She wasn't unhappy in any way with her relationship, and anyway, this wasn't about that.

He looked at her for a moment like someone not sure they recognize a half-famous person, then stepped past. She turned, watching him from

behind, her eyes low. How dare you not look over your shoulder at me, she thought, and when he suddenly did, she startled and spun away, caught.

Inside, she left the box on the kitchen table unopened. Mason was out getting groceries, and the apartment felt airless, still. She paced briefly, then walked to the mirror and pulled her top over her head, studying the loose thread he'd touched. Nothing was wrong with the shirt. She pulled on something tighter.

The next time they spoke, it was halfway in the stairwell. Mason had gone to a bookstore reading downtown, he was good about supporting colleagues like that. Lauren lingered by the railing just outside the door, pretending to scroll through her phone as though distracted by something enough to make her stop. Caleb came in from outside, shirt off this time, his skin slick with sweat and the faint outline of a key card in his waistband. He smiled when he saw her.

"You're always right there when I pass by," he said.

She hesitated, then smiled back. "Maybe you're the one who's always passing when I'm minding my own business out here."

He stopped a step below her giving her the advantage in height, but somehow it felt like the opposite. His eyes traveled up her bare legs, and slowly, too, like that was the only way he knew how to look at her now.

"What are you listening to?" she asked, nodding at the cord still dangling near his chest.

"Nothing right now," he said. "But you wanna hear something?"

She said yes without deciding to, and he handed her one bud. She took it, holding it to her ear without inserting it. A low beat played, sensual and deep. She nodded to it, but it was nothing she recognized, not even the genre. They stood like that, close but not touching, listening to his tunes.

Finally giving up the pretense of being sophisticated enough, she took out the bud and lifted her chin, gesturing to him. "What is it?"

"This," he said, taking the ear bud back and winding up the cord in his hand. "Is the best music of Ghana, Sarkodie."

"It's nice," she said, and she turned and nearly ran away up the stairs.

He watched her go and laughed that deep laugh of his again. "It's good, no?" he said to the blank wall.

When Mason got home, she was rearranging dishes in the cabinet and vacuuming the floor.

She started taking longer routes home from work, not because she was avoiding anything, but because she wasn't ready to walk straight in. Not ready to risk it again. Her keys stayed in her purse a little longer, her hand lingering on the gate or the railing, her pace slowing near the landing. She caught herself pausing at the same stair, the one where she first stood above him, where he'd looked up she'd not flinched.

What, she wondered, was she missing that she would do these things? Nothing, she insisted to herself. He was just a distraction, that man upstairs.

Saturday morning, she stepped out with the recycling. Her hair was still damp from the shower, tied up carelessly, no makeup, and wearing one of Mason's old t-shirts that hung just above her thighs. She didn't think anyone would see her, it was that early. She opened the bin lid with her foot and dropped the flattened boxes in, then turned and nearly walked straight into Caleb.

"Hey," he said, steadying the lid with one hand so it didn't slam shut.

She stepped back, swallowed her startle reaction. "Hey. Sorry, I wasn't looking." She screwed up at her face sideways. Looking for what?

He glanced down at her shirt, then back up to her eyes. "And I didn't mean to sneak up on you."

She tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. "Just doing the glamorous chores," she laughed.

His eyes stayed on her face this time, softer now. "I like you like this."

She laughed again, not sure how to react. She crossed her arms, shifted her weight to her other hip, but she didn't retreat. "Like what?"

"Natural," he said. "No filters."

"I'm not a filter girl."

"You could be. But you're much better than that."

She looked down, bit her lip. The silence didn't feel awkward anymore, but it hummed. She reached for the doorknob, not turning it yet, just holding it.

"Have you got plans today? It's Saturday," he said.

"Mason's working. I might go out later."

"I'm heading out for a run. You want to come with me?"

She looked up sharply, then smiled, unsure. "I'm not a runner."

"You don't have to be. You just have to walk fast and pretend." He laughed.

She laughed too, but he tilted his head, waiting as though the offer was for real. She hesitated, then said, “Maybe another time, Caleb..”

He nodded, stepped back, and jogged down the front path. She watched until he turned the corner, then exhaled and stepped inside, her heartbeat louder than the closing door.

In the bathroom, she wiped under her eyes as though removing makeup she hadn’t worn. Her reflection looked unsettled. Not ashamed, but charged, like something was happening to her body from the outside in. She leaned forward bracing the counter, and stared until her breathing slowed.

That afternoon, she put on leggings and a light top, one with a plunging neckline she usually saved for dinners out. Mason noticed. “You going somewhere?”

“Just felt like not being such a slob today,” she laughed.

He nodded, got distracted by his screen, and she stepped out for a walk that had no destination. Just walk fast, he said, as if. She came back, past the street, then turned back, then up the front steps where she still saw no one. His door was open a crack at the top of the stairs and she didn’t look away fast enough.

It swung open just a little bit more as she passed on the hallway below. There was no creak, no call from inside, just a subtle movement like a breeze or a shadow. Lauren kept walking, but slower now, the hairs on her arms lifting as if touched by current. She didn’t glance back until she reached her door, and even then, she only saw the door still ajar, still quiet, as though waiting. Her breath drew tight in her chest until she made it through her door and back into their apartment.

That night, she was distracted. Mason suggested a movie, one of the old ones he loved, and she curled against him on the couch, her legs tucked under, but her attention drifted. When he leaned to kiss her, she kissed back but didn’t deepen it. She smiled and shifted, adjusted the blanket, and he returned to watching. But inside she was a storm.

The next morning, she stepped out early to catch the sun while it was still low. The front walkway was warm already, concrete drying in patches. She sat on the steps in gym shorts and a zip hoodie, coffee in one hand, legs stretched out across the bottom stair. Her hair was pulled high.

She didn’t expect him so early, but Caleb stepped out of the building barefoot, holding a jug of water and blinking in the morning light. He didn’t see her until he was halfway down the steps.

“Oh, didn’t mean to crash your morning,” he said, voice still rough from sleep.

She sipped. “You live here too.”

He sat on the railing, stretched one leg along the edge, the other hanging. His shirt rode up slightly. She didn’t look directly but knew the line of his waist was visible. He drank from the jug and handed it to her without asking. She took it, her lips brushing the rim, then passed it back without speaking.

“You good?” he asked, watching her.

She nodded, but a little too quickly. “Just up early.”

He didn’t press her on it. But he stayed there, quiet beside her, letting the silence fill the air between them like a different kind of heat. Her foot brushed his shin, lightly, accidentally, but neither of them moved. She stood finally, brushing off the back of her shorts. “I should go back in.”

He nodded, but as she passed him, his hand caught her wrist, not tightly, not urgently, but enough. She paused looking down at the fingers around her arm. He let go just as gently, and when she looked up, his eyes were already lowered, respectfully and unreadable.

“I’m not pushing,” he said. “I guess I wanted you to stay with me a little longer. I shouldn’t have done that.”

She didn’t answer. She turned and went inside, pulse tapping like a finger on glass. She closed the door softly, leaned her back into it, and stayed there a moment, her eyes closed.

He remained on the railing unmoving, sipping again from the water jug, eyes cast toward the street but unfocused, like watching something replay in his mind.

The next time was small and came without plan or warning, slipping in sideways like everything else. Lauren had gone out late to pick up a few things, milk, coffee, some kind of sparkling drink Mason liked chilled in the evenings. She came back with the grocery bag clutched against her chest, digging one hand into her purse for the keys, when the door opened. She didn’t have to look. The timing told her who it was.

“You’re out late,” Caleb said, standing barefoot again, a t-shirt loose over his frame, gym shorts hanging low on his hips. He held a laundry basket at his side.

Lauren kept her head lowered a second longer, then looked up with a smile. “Just grabbing some things.”

He nodded, stepped down two stairs, then paused. "Here," he said, holding out his hand. "That bag looks heavy."

"It's fine," she said, but didn't resist when he took it from her anyway, his fingers brushing hers for the second time. His hand stayed longer than necessary but not long enough to make her move.

He carried it to the door for her, holding it in one hand while his other braced the doorframe, his arm outstretched above her. She ducked down under his arm and unlocked it slowly, aware of how close he was behind her, how the night air cooled her legs, and the hallway smelled faintly of detergent from the basket he carried.

"Thanks," she said as the door clicked open. He handed the bag over but didn't step inside.

"You always look good," he said, low, not pressing, spoken like it was a simple truth delivered without needing a response.

She stood still, her grip tight on the bag. "You say that a lot."

"I mean it every time."

She nodded. "You should get your laundry done before it's midnight."

He smiled at that, his head dipping once. "Right," he said and he smiled and saluted.

She closed the door softly between them and leaned against it again, heart fluttering madly.

Later, when Mason was brushing his teeth and the bathroom fan was running, she pulled her phone out and stared at the screen. No messages and nothing from Caleb. But of course not, he hadn't asked for her number. But her body tingled anyway, like it was waiting for something from him. She set the phone down and slid beneath the sheets, Mason already half-asleep beside her.

Her dreams were vivid and disjointed: hands that weren't Mason's brushing her thigh, lips grazing the inside of her wrist, breath near her ear. She woke warm, flushed between the legs, and pressed her thighs together beneath the sheets without moving. She kept her eyes closed, pretending to still be asleep, even after Mason rolled away and got up to make coffee.

She stayed like that until she heard the front door below open, then close again. Only then did she reach under the covers and slide her hand between her legs, just for a minute, just to take the edge off.

Mason was great. They had a solid thing between them. There was no daylight for anything or anyone to get between them.

But Caleb kept popping up like that, and now invading her dreams, too.

She didn't go upstairs of course, not even when she thought how she might, how she could. Knock on his door. Disrupt him for a change the way he'd disrupted her so much lately. She didn't go up there even when Mason was stepped out for the day and she stayed home, the apartment quiet except for the ticking of the old pipes.

Instead, she waited. She sat at the kitchen table in a pale, ribbed tank with no bra and a pair of soft, frayed shorts she usually only wore to bed. She didn't clean, didn't read, just let time pass . . . and listened for footsteps on the stairs.

They came late in the afternoon.

She heard him descend, then stop. He paused on the landing. Then came a knock, soft, almost hesitant. Her heart skipped and she waited a beat, but then rose and opened the door, her fingers light on the handle, pretending she hadn't been standing just a few feet away.

Caleb leaned into the frame with a crooked smile. "Wasn't sure if you were in."

"I was. I am."

He glanced at her bare legs. "Hoped you might be."

She stepped back but didn't speak. He looked past her, eyes sweeping the room behind her. "He's out?"

She nodded. "Yeah." She tucked loose hair behind her ear.

He didn't move forward, he just waited.

Lauren didn't invite him in, either, but she left the door open and walked to the couch and sat with her legs tucked beneath her. He followed her, slowly, quietly, closing the door behind him with care, as though trying not to make it real too quickly.

"You always this quiet?" he asked, standing over her.

"No," she said. "Not always." She defied him with her eyes looking straight back at his.

He sat beside her but didn't lean in. His knee brushed hers. "You've been waiting for something."

Her eyes stayed on his. "I didn't say that."

"You didn't have to," he said shrugging.

He reached out now, slow enough to stop if she flinched. She didn't. His hand landed on her knee, fingers trailing upward, just grazing the inside of her thigh. Her breath caught, but her body didn't pull away. He moved his

hand higher. She shifted now, just slightly, and the edge of her shorts pulled tighter.

“Tell me to stop,” he said.

She didn’t.

He leaned closer, his mouth near her cheek, his breath slow, his hand paused just under the hem. She remained still, trembling slightly. Then her hand lifted and caught his wrist, not to push it away, but to hold it in place.

And that was enough.

He moved then, guiding her gently back until her spine met the cushions. His mouth brushed her collarbone, then up her neck, and her eyes fluttered. Her legs opened just a little, one knee falling sideways, allowing him between them. His palm slid over her hip, then under her shirt, feeling the heat of her bare stomach.

She whispered something he couldn’t hear. It might have been his name, might have just been air. He kissed her again, slower now, and she responded fully this time, her lips opening beneath his, her hips arching up into his thigh that pressed on her. Her fingers curled in his shirt, her breaths coming shallow and fast.

Then they both froze at the same time. A key turned in the door.

Lauren bolted upright, hair wild, eyes wide. Caleb was already up stepping toward the hall. She spun off the couch and ducked behind the kitchen counter as the door swung open.

Mason stepped inside with one arm full of books, the other reaching back to lock the door behind him. “You wouldn’t believe the deal I found,” he said, heading straight for the table without noticing anything out of place.

Lauren crouched behind the counter, heart hammering, her breathing tight and high in her chest. Caleb had vanished into the hallway in a flash, the bathroom door now silently cracked closed. She smoothed her shirt down, pulled the hem of her shorts lower, and rose slowly, pretending she’d just stepped in from the hallway.

Mason turned. “There you are.”

“Was in the bedroom,” she said, voice steady enough to pass.

“Check this out,” he said, flipping through a dog-eared hardback. “First edition. I think the guy didn’t know what he had.”

She stepped over, brushing her fingers through her hair, glancing toward the hall where Caleb remained hidden. Her pulse hadn’t settled. Mason kept flipping pages, oblivious.

“I’m gonna hop in the shower,” she said, backing away, forcing herself not to look toward the bathroom. “Walked around a bunch today. I’m gross.”

He waved a hand. “Go for it.”

She passed the bathroom on her way to the bedroom and gave the barest tap to the door as she did, not enough to be heard unless you were waiting for it. She undressed in her room in silence, tugging on a robe. She stood beside the door and waited, a towel from the linen closet over her arm.

A moment passed, and then Caleb slipped silently out, shoes in hand, eyes flicking once toward hers as he moved past her. She didn’t speak and neither did he. But he let his eyes draw down her robe and back up.

The front door clicked shut.

She stepped under the shower finally, letting the water pound her skin. Her thighs tingled from where his hand had traveled. Her lips still remembered his mouth. She braced both palms on the tile and exhaled hard. She hadn’t said no. She’d wanted it, God, she still did, but Mason was ten feet away with his headphones on and a book on his lap, completely unaware of the way her knees had nearly given out a moment earlier.

What was wrong with her? Why was she doing this? She rolled her forehead over the hard tile in the shower, and the water poured steaming over her back.

That night, Mason made dinner. They watched a film while eating on the couch. He laid his head in her lap and looked up at her like nothing was going on. She played with his hair, smiling when he said something funny, but her eyes kept drifting to the door, her skin still humming from earlier.

When Mason undressed and reached for her in bed, she kissed him softly, sweetly, then turned and curled into his chest, pretending to sleep. He didn’t press her. She felt his arm settle around her waist and her eyes stayed open long after his had closed.

Upstairs, Caleb lay awake, too, one arm behind his head, the other across his chest, remembering the heat of her skin under that thin shirt and the way she hadn’t pulled away.

They didn’t see each other for two days. Lauren stayed inside more than usual, half out of guilt, half out of confusion, and maybe a little out of fear too, fear of what she’d do the next time she saw him. Mason was home often, headphones on, writing stretches broken up by coffee runs and long

monologues about plot fixes she barely followed. She smiled and nodded, made food, kissed him goodbye when he stepped out.

She found herself checking the hallway before opening the door, waiting longer on the porch in case he passed. He didn't.

On the third day, she heard the weights. They thudded softly through the ceiling in a rhythm she recognized now. She stood under the noise, pretending to tidy a shelf, and counted the repetitions. Her body warmed just listening to him. When the sound stopped, she paced the kitchen for ten minutes before finally stepping out with a bag of trash, the excuse flimsy, but the need real.

She didn't expect him to be there, but he was. He stood outside the building, shirtless, his chest rising and falling, a sheen of sweat on his shoulders, a towel slung over his neck. He was leaning against the railing, water bottle in hand. When she stepped down, he looked up immediately.

Neither of them said anything at first.

Then: "You okay?" he asked, voice quiet.

She stopped a step above him. "I don't know actually."

He nodded once. "Me either." He looked down and grimaced, shook his head.

Her fingers clenched tighter around the trash bag. She looked down at it, then dropped it into the bin and brushed her hands on her thighs. She didn't move back to the door right away.

Caleb stepped forward, not closing the distance all the way, but enough that she had to look up to meet his eyes. "You don't have to say anything," he said. "I just wanted to see you again, but for real this time."

She hesitated and her breathing slowed. Her eyes stayed locked to his.

"Mason's gone tomorrow," she offered barely above a whisper. "All day."

Caleb didn't smile. He just nodded as if confirming something already decided.

"What time?" he asked.

"After noon. He's going to meet his editor downtown. Then some social thing. He doesn't get back till after midnight."

His eyes searched her face. "You want that?"

She paused, and then she nodded.

He stepped back, the space between them growing again, and she turned and walked inside. Her knees didn't feel steady until she reached the

bedroom. She sat on the edge of the bed, hands in her lap, staring at the hardwood floor like it would give her instructions.

That night she didn't sleep at all.

She showered twice, shaved everything, changed outfits three times, before settling on one and then changing again anyway. She watched Mason pack up his laptop and notes, kiss her on the forehead, and leave with a smile. She waited five minutes after the door shut before she moved.

She opened the door slowly, expecting him to already be there, waiting in the hall. But it was empty. She wore a robe only, and she drew the sash more tightly around her. The building was still and silent, that midafternoon hush where the world outside moved on without her. She closed the door again and leaned against it, her hands trembling. This is wrong, so wrong, she thought to herself. What was she doing? Why?

Then came the knock, three soft taps, spaced like a question.

She opened it without a word.

Caleb stepped inside, clean now, dressed in a dark shirt that hugged his chest and loose expensive jeans that sat low on his waist. He didn't reach for her, he just stood still, letting the moment settle, the air dense with things unsaid.

Lauren didn't speak either. She backed up slowly, her eyes locked on his. He followed, quiet, unhurried, until the door clicked shut behind him and they were alone.

She turned and walked to the bedroom.

He followed at the same steady pace, his footsteps barely audible on the old floor. When she reached the foot of the bed, she stopped, her back to him. She let the robe slip from her shoulders, the cotton whispering as it fell. Beneath it she wore nothing, no bra, no panties, just her skin, warm and flushed.

Caleb didn't make a sound.

She heard him exhale through his nose, soft and low, then felt his hands on her hips, broad, steady, and warm. He didn't pull her to him, he only held her like she might run, even though she wasn't going anywhere. Her breath stuttered as his mouth touched the back of her neck, then lower, slow kisses tracing the line of her spine. Her body softened under his touch, the tension she'd carried all morning melting with every press of his lips.

He turned her gently, not forcing, just guiding her, until she faced him. Her eyes were wide, locked on his. She raised one hand and touched his

chest, then let it slide down, catching the edge of his shirt. He lifted it over his head and dropped it on the floor.

He kissed her then, soft at first, slow enough to taste her, to let her respond. Her hands slid up his torso, then around his shoulders as she leaned into him, her bare chest pressing against his. The contact made her gasp into his mouth, and he swallowed the sound, deepening the kiss.

She broke away just enough to catch her breath, then dropped to her knees without speaking.

His eyes darkened. He stood still as she unfastened his jeans and pulled them down, then reached for the waistband of his briefs, watching his reaction the entire time. He didn't stop her and he didn't move. He just watched, his hands hanging loosely at his sides.

She slid them all the way down and reached for him, her fingers wrapping around him slowly, her lips parting. She looked up once more, her eyes wide and uncertain, glancing between his two eyes back and forth, but when he nodded, she leaned forward and took him into her mouth.

She started slow, shallow and teasing. He hissed through his teeth, one hand brushing her hair back as she found a rhythm, then sank deeper on him.

She grew bolder as she moved, her tongue tracing the underside of his length before she took him deeper still, her hands sliding up his thighs for balance. Her lips stayed soft, her jaw working gently, the pace slow but steady. She could feel his restraint in the way he gripped her hair, not pulling, but holding her, as if trying to anchor himself. His breathing thickened. He looked down at her, not speaking, his abs flexing with each pass of her mouth over him.

When she glanced up again, her eyes were glassy. Her cheeks hollowed around him, her body shifting forward for better leverage. He grunted softly, but when her motion grew too intense, he caught her chin and pulled her off with a wet popping sound, his chest rising hard.

She sat back on her heels, wiping the corner of her mouth with the back of her hand, flushed and breathing quickly. He pulled her up, both hands on her hips now, his forehead pressing against her chest.

"I want to taste you," he said.

She didn't answer but she leaned back onto her elbows, then let her spine sink into the bed, drawing her knees up and spreading her thighs slowly.

Her feet curled, her stomach fluttering under the tension of being fully exposed, she shut her eyes.

Caleb didn't rush. He moved down her body with long, slow kisses, one between her breasts, one lower across her stomach, then lower still.

When he finally pressed his mouth between her legs, she gasped. His tongue moved in slow, deliberate circles, lips warm against the most sensitive skin. Her thighs tensed, then relaxed, only to tighten again as he found the spot that made her whimper. He stayed there, patient and focused, his tongue flicking gently, then harder, then slow again. She threaded her fingers into his hair and arched her back, her head rolling to the side.

Her breathing quickened, legs trembling, her grip on him tightening when he sucked softly, holding her open with his hands. She moaned his name once, barely audibly, like she didn't mean to say it out loud.

It was the tension of the several past weeks, she thought to herself. It was the wrongness of it, as though that should make it better, faster. But while she recognized the sensations, she was wholly unprepared for their rapid escalation and relentless upward spiral.

She tapped at his head, clenched in her gut. What was he doing to her, on her? It was giving her no space, no time. Her hips danced under his face, her fingers searched for sheets to clench. Her head rolled side to side, her hair whipped over her face. Still he wasn't being fair.

She inhaled and held her breath and the rush of it, the way it uncoiled from deep inside her and lashed her with waves of warmth, it was like nothing else she'd ever experienced. She cried out loud, "I'm gong to come!" as though surprised, and no sooner had she said it, her spine curled back, her head rolled so far she was facing the wall behind her upside down, and her body spasmed as though electrocuted.

It was sudden and full, her whole body curling as a long, broken cry escaped her throat. He stayed with her through it, his mouth never leaving her until her legs twitched and she begged under her breath for a pause. He kissed the inside of her thigh and looked up at her, his lips glistening with her dew.

She looked down, dazed, her chest still heaving.

He stood and undressed fully now, his body lean and hard, the lines of his stomach tapering low. She reached for him before he even joined her on the bed, pulling him down over her greedily as she opened her legs again,

wrapping them around his waist. Her hands roamed his back, her hips rising instinctively. There was nothing stopping her.

“Are you sure?” he asked, voice thick.

She nodded, biting her lip, her eyes locked to his. “Don’t make me beg.”

He lined himself against her and pressed slowly, his weight braced on his forearms, his eyes never leaving hers. She held her breath, her nails biting into his shoulders as he entered her inch by inch. Her legs tightened around him, her thighs drawing him closer. She gasped when he sank all the way in, her back arching off the bed as her body stretched to take him.

Caleb stayed still at first, letting her adjust to him, his lips brushing her cheek, then her jaw. Her hands moved from his back to his sides, then down, tracing the curve of his hips as if memorizing the shape of him inside her. When he pulled back and pushed in again, slower this time, she moaned deep into his neck.

Every thrust came deeper. He moved with control, each roll of his hips solid, drawing out her breath in short, helpless gasps. Her legs moved higher, locking over his neck, pulling him in. She tilted her pelvis upward to meet him, grinding against him with growing urgency. The wet sound of their bodies meeting filled the room now, her thighs slick, her chest rising into his with every movement.

He picked up pace as her own confidence taking him grew, her moans no longer shy, her fingers digging into his arms as she whispered filthy things against his mouth. Her voice was unrecognizable, hoarse, raw, needy. She begged for it harder, for him to give her everything, to fuck her like they didn’t have a clock ticking somewhere outside that room.

He gave her exactly that. His hands slid beneath her back, lifting her into him. The angle deepened, and she cried out, biting his shoulder to muffle the sound. He thrust harder now, rougher, driving into her until the bed shifted under them. She met every stroke with abandon, her hips rolling, her arms clinging to him like she might float away if she let go.

When he slowed, it wasn’t to stop, it was to flip her. He pulled out, turned her gently onto her stomach, then lifted her hips from behind. She exhaled hard when he entered her again, deeper than before, the position forcing her open. Her cheek pressed to the sheets, her fists gripping the blanket. He held her by the hips and thrust into her steadily, watching the way her body responded to every push.

She was wild now, moaning into the sheet, meeting every stroke of his with hungry, unrestrained movement. She reached between her legs and touched herself, the pressure sending her spiraling. Caleb cursed under his breath, barely holding on. She was close again, he could feel it in the way her legs tensed, the way she shook, the way she gripped him inside, fluttered and contracted around him.

“I’m gonna come,” she gasped, voice ragged.

“Come for me,” he growled, thrusting harder, deeper.

She came hard, her whole body convulsing, her loud cries barely muffled into the sheets. He followed seconds later, groaning low as he emptied himself into her, his grip tightening before his whole frame softened against her back.

They fell over sideways and stayed joined like that for a long time, tangled, their bodies swamped and unmoving, the sound of their breathing the only thing in the room. Caleb eased out slowly, carefully, his hand tracing her spine as he pulled away. Lauren didn’t speak. She stayed on her stomach, eyes closed, cheek resting on the damp sheet, lips parted.

He leaned down and kissed the back of her shoulder before sitting back on the edge of the bed. His chest rose and fell as he looked over at her, the red marks from his hands still faint on her thighs.

She rolled onto her side eventually, blinking up at the ceiling, her legs drawn together loosely. Her voice was hoarse when she spoke. “That was . . .”

He turned slightly. “Yeah.”

She pulled the sheet up to her waist, not to cover herself but to anchor her hands. “I don’t know what I thought it would feel like.”

Caleb watched her a moment. “Do you regret it?”

Her eyes shifted to his. “No.” She grinned with a touch of nervousness.

He nodded. “That’s good.”

She sat up slowly, the ache in her thighs delicious and real. Her hair was a mess, her mouth swollen, her skin marked in places she hadn’t realized he’d touched. She looked at herself in the long mirror across from the bed and felt a strange sense of calm settle in. She didn’t feel broken or ashamed. She felt awakened. It wasn’t sex like that, she told herself. It was a work out, it was private, it was an exploration. “A provocation,” as she would have said back in college.

Caleb stood and pulled his clothes on in pieces, slowly, his body still humming with the weight of it. He came back to the bed, leaned down, and kissed her, softly this time, almost chaste.

“I’ll go before it gets weird,” he said.

“It’s already weird,” she murmured through a crooked grin.

He smiled and touched her cheek. “Then I’ll go before it gets worse.”

She didn’t walk him out. She stayed seated on the edge of the bed, watching the door close quietly behind him. When it latched, she let out a breath she didn’t know she was holding and dropped back onto the pillows.

The apartment stayed quiet for another hour. She cleaned up slowly, not erasing anything, but softening it. Sheets in the hamper, window cracked open, shower running hot. She dressed in the outfit she would’ve worn if nothing had happened. By the time Mason got home, the apartment smelled faintly of cleaner and fresh air, and little else.

He kissed her cheek and dropped his bag. “I got the files,” he said. “They pushed the deadline, though, so I’ve got some breathing room.”

“That’s good,” she said, smiling like normal.

He didn’t notice the extra flush in her cheeks or the faint mark at her collarbone. She kept her legs crossed when they sat for a snack, her tone light, her questions attentive. She even laughed at the right places in his telling her how it went.

Later that night, when he touched her in bed, she let him. She even pulled him closer, pulled him over her. But something in her felt different now, something still glowing, still warm. He hadn’t noticed, but she had.

When her boyfriend came inside her, the word suddenly came to her: “Dimensional,” she nearly said out loud. Like how poverty could be both from personal choices and external circumstances — it was dimensional, the same thing from two disparate sources. It was one word but meant two different things.

It was dimensional, what she was doing. Sex with Mason was one thing, sex with Caleb was a whole other thing, same word, but two completely different things.

That now settled, she slept instantly and more soundly than she had in days, now she had Caleb’s number, and he had hers, that man just above them even now.

The Time My Girlfriend Got to Know the Neighbor

The doorframe creaked when Devin leaned against it, one thick forearm pressed above his head, his other hand casually spinning a keyring around one finger. Down the hall, Katie had just bent over to pull a baking tray from the oven, the hem of her loose gym shorts riding high under the oversized tee she wore without a bra. She didn't see him at first. The fan was on, the oven door open, and she was muttering to herself about forgetting the time.

Devin cleared his throat.

She startled and half-turned, her cheeks coloring immediately, though her smile was automatic.

"Sorry," she said, standing straight. "Didn't hear you."

"I knocked. Guess you were too busy being cute," he said, the keyring now landing in his palm. "Smells good. You bakin' something up for your man?"

"Just cinnamon rolls. From the can," she added quickly, brushing her hair behind one ear. "They're nothing."

"They smell like sex," he said, grinning. "Mind if I steal one?"

He was already halfway into their apartment.

She stepped aside, trying not to notice how close he passed or how large he felt. The ceiling above Devin's place had a leak again, and that had brought him down earlier in the week. This time he said something about checking how the moisture was traveling down the wall, claiming it might affect the shared pipe.

He never stayed long but he also never left without touching something, her wrist when passing behind her, her lower back when moving around her in the narrow hallway. It was always light contact, always brief, always plausibly deniable.

Devin reached for one of the cinnamon rolls with his fingers, and bit into it like he hadn't eaten all day.

“Mmm. Hot,” he said with his mouth full, nodding. “You made these just for me didn’t you.”

Katie smiled but she didn’t answer. How could she have, she thought to herself. She didn’t even know he was coming down to visit.

Devin stepped closer to her. “That’s a yes ain’t it.”

“I make them for anybody who likes them,” she said, glancing toward the bedroom door, which was open. The clacking of laptop keys came from inside, where Mark was working. “You want a plate of them?”

He didn’t answer, but chewed slowly, looking at her face, all around it, exposing her, teasing her.

“You got some sugar on your lip,” he said finally.

She reached up to wipe it, but he was already lifting his hand. His thumb brushed the corner of her mouth.

“There,” he said far too intimately.

Her mouth remained half-open, unsure whether to thank him or to step back from him. She dabbed her pinky in the corner of her mouth as though to reclaim in from him.

He let his hand fall but didn’t move away and she didn’t either, though they were now too close. She remained that close until the chair scraped in the other room and Mark muttered something about his charger. Only then did she shift sideways, stepping around Devin quickly, her whole body now tense with embarrassed heat.

“Anyway,” she said, already at the sink, “I should . . .”

“I’ll let you two enjoy your treats,” he said, licking his thumb, eyes sparkling at her.

Katie watched him slide back down the long hallway and he knew she was watching him, which is why he let her without turning around.

Mark came out of their bedroom rubbing his eyes, cables in his hands. He kissed her cheek in passing heading for the router outlet near the coffee table. “You said the rolls were done?”

Katie nodded, her back turned as she rinsed a bowl. Her hands lingered in the warm water. She inhaled deeply and blew the air out her circled lips slow and measured

“Cool. I’ll grab one later.”

She could feel the air from the open door still moving faintly around her legs. She glanced over and saw it hadn’t latched. Devin hadn’t closed it all the way. A sliver of hallway was still visible, the floor out there worn

smooth by years of foot traffic. She went down the hallway, leaned out to look, and latched the door shut.

That night she told herself she wouldn't think about him again. It was just one of those weird little moments. Flirting but only kind of. He was just a friendly neighbor, that was just his way of being charming, he couldn't help it. He was older, bolder, and probably like that with everyone. She didn't do anything wrong.

Still, when she lay down beside Mark and he rolled over to kiss her, all she could think about was the pressure of Devin's thumb on her lip. And the way he took his sweet time with his eyes looking at her up and down and up again.

The next time Devin came by, it was early afternoon. Katie had just come out of the shower, hair damp, skin warm from the water. She wore Mark's T-shirt and a pair of tight cotton shorts. The buzzer rang just as she was brushing lotion down her legs, and she nearly didn't answer. But her feet were moving before her brain even discussed the pros and cons.

"Hey," she said, peeking through the crack in the door, a big smile she also didn't intend.

"Water pressure upstairs's all messed," Devin said with his usual crooked grin. "You mind if I try yours real quick? Just the bathroom sink. Won't be a minute."

She hesitated, but he was already stepping forward, and her fingers slipped from the knob before she could stop him.

He passed close again, even brushing against her this time. The heat of him filled the hallway behind her, and she could feel the air shift when he moved past.

The bathroom door clicked closed. She stood frozen in the middle of the kitchen, trying not to feel ridiculous. Her hair wasn't done. Her legs were bare. She hadn't put on a bra.

A minute passed. Then two. When he stepped out, his sleeves were rolled up and water dripped from his hands. He wiped them casually on the sides of his jeans.

"You got great pressure down here," he said, looking at her bare legs. "Like, strong. Real smooth." He only slowly lifted his eyes up her body with that grin again.

She blinked. "What?"

“Your water,” he said, making eyes. “Real smooth stream. Not like mine.”

She smiled, flustered now.

He looked around. “You home alone?”

“Mark’s out getting groceries.”

Devin made himself at home in their kitchen, leaned his hip against the counter.

“You know,” he said, “if you ever want to try a workout sometime, I got gear upstairs. Not creepin’ or anything, just sayin’. You got good muscle tone. Surprised you don’t already.”

Her throat tightened, but she didn’t look away.

He stepped off the counter, walking past her again toward the door. “Offer’s open.”

Then he was gone.

She stood there another full minute before remembering to breathe. What was he doing to her?

Katie didn’t tell Mark about it but not because it was a secret. It just hadn’t crossed any lines. And anyway, there wasn’t much to tell. Devin had used the sink, said something about water pressure, then left, and that was all. She told herself that twice while folding laundry, edited it while checking her phone, and rehearsed it while she was brushing her teeth that night.

Still, she picked a particular top the next day, one that clung a little more, but still looked casual. She tied her hair back but left a few strands loose down the sides of her face, told herself it was just because it was hot.

But Devin didn’t come.

Three days later, she was carrying two grocery bags in each hand, fumbling for her keys, when she heard him behind her.

“Need a hand?”

He reached easily over her shoulder, unlocked the door for her, then stepped back and held it open. She could feel the heat of him behind her again, so close she had to squeeze through sideways. He didn’t move back and she brushed his chest as she passed, also not trying that hard not to touch. Why is it always on her, she thought.

“Thanks,” she said, breathless from the bags. “You always catch me at the worst moment.”

“Nah,” he said, letting the door close behind them. “Always catch you at the perfect ones.”

She turned to look at him, expecting a wink or a grin, but his face remained still, his eyes on her lips.

“Want me to carry some of those for you?”

“No, I got it,” she said.

He took two anyway, brushing her fingers as he lifted them from her hands. Their arms grazed, before he turned and walked ahead of her all the way up and into her kitchen like he’d been there a hundred times before. She followed him, trying to slow her breathing.

He set the bags on the counter and looked around.

“No boyfriend around today?”

“He’s at the bookstore.”

Devin leaned back against the fridge.

“Your place smells good again,” he said. “Like last time.”

“It’s the soap probably.”

“Nah. Pretty sure it’s you.”

She smiled but said nothing and he took a step closer.

“You want to come up sometime?” he asked. “Just to hang. I got a few records, some drinks. Coffee with oat milk, right? Nothing heavy.”

“I’m not really. . .” she started but stopped, unsure.

“No pressure,” he said, voice softer now. “Just company, right?”

She didn’t answer. Her hands gripped the counter edge behind her.

Devin stepped back. “Offer’s still open,” he said, like it was a friendly reminder. “You got a good vibe. I do like being around you.”

Then he turned and walked out, letting the door swing slowly shut behind him.

Katie stood there for a long while, not moving, still feeling the pressure of the bags in her fingers. She heard his footsteps recede down the hallway and thought about him being up there, about whether he’d said all that just to see how far she’d go. Would it be okay to go up and see his work out set up? To go up just to hang out? Hear his records? She rehearsed how that would sound, explaining it.

She told herself ultimately she wouldn’t go upstairs. She didn’t believe she ever could. She wouldn’t allow herself.

The next morning, she woke up before Mark. She slipped out of bed quietly and wandered barefoot to the kitchen, not intending to do anything

there, but she couldn't lie in bed anymore, either. When she opened the fridge and realized she was out of oat milk, her eyes lifted toward the ceiling. Toward the apartment above.

She didn't go up. It was almost noon when she heard the knock. She leaned out and found Devin's head sideways, grinning at her. His shirt was off and he was just in shorts, sneakers, and a towel draped over one shoulder.

"Didn't think you'd be home," he said.

Katie blinked. "What are you . . ." She started, her eyes wondering as freely around his torso as he had got comfortable letting his eyes travel around her body.

"I was stretching out. Getting ready, wondering if you wanted to come work out with me."

She glanced over her shoulder, but Mark was still snoring faintly.

"I got cold ice coffees," Devin said, still leaning in. "You want some of that." He waved them under her nose.

She hesitated and he watched her mouth.

"One," she said. "Down here. Then you go."

He grinned wider. "Deal."

By the time she opened the door and let him in, he'd pulled on his tank top. His skin still glistened. She poured two glasses from the bottles he brought down and handed him one, then leaned against the far counter, arms crossed, keeping her distance.

Devin drank half of his, then set the glass down.

"You look real good today."

She shook her head, laughed. "I literally just rolled out of bed."

"Exactly."

He stepped closer.

"I don't think this is a good idea," she said softly, and she glanced down the hall again.

"You haven't done anything," he said. "I haven't either. Yet," he added and he laughed.

She still didn't move when he reached out and ran the back of his finger down her bare arm. Her body registered the touch before her mind caught up. His hand was large, his fingertip slow and deliberate. She felt it in her stomach, and lower, too.

"You want me to stop?" he asked.

She didn't say anything.

He stepped forward again, just a breath away now. She could feel the heat coming off him.

"You sure?" he asked again.

She shook her head, but slightly, then whispered, "You agreed just one cup."

Devin smiled and leaned in, not for a kiss, but near enough to her neck, his voice low.

"I drink slow."

She was breathing faster now, but didn't pull away. When he touched her waist, she let him. When his thumb slid under the hem of her shirt to find her bare skin there, she closed her eyes.

The creak of a bedframe from the other room broke the moment like glass. Devin stepped back immediately, grabbed his glass, and headed for the door.

"Thanks for the coffee," he said, casual again.

Katie stared after him, face flushed, heart pounding, her legs unsteady. "It was your coffee, you dummy," she said.

Mark shuffled out of the bedroom moments later, rubbing his eyes, mumbling something about needing food.

Katie handed him the rest of her now room temperature cold brew without a word.

Mark didn't notice anything and he never did. He drank the coffee while scrolling his phone, half-laughing at some meme, then wandered off to shower, humming under his breath. Katie watched him go, chest still tight, thighs pressed together. Her pulse hadn't come down.

She cleaned the kitchen twice that morning.

Devin didn't come back that day or the next. She hated how often she looked at the ceiling. Hated even more that she'd started dressing with him in mind, looser shirts without a bra, or shorts that had gotten too tight in the wash but still rode low in a way she'd noticed him notice.

It wasn't like she planned anything. But when the faucet in the bathroom started sputtering two nights later, she didn't even hesitate. She texted him. "Water acting up down here now, you broke it, you fix it!"

The reply came in seconds. "omw"

She changed shirts. Then changed back. Her legs were bare. Her feet too. She left it that way.

Devin knocked lightly, like it was already their thing. When she opened the door, he held a wrench and a flashlight. She nodded and stepped aside, and he brushed past, the back of his hand grazing her hip. She pushed her hip forward to extend the contact. He only glanced at her over his shoulder.

“Bathroom?” he asked.

She nodded, following him.

Inside, he crouched by the sink, fiddled with a valve, flashlight tucked under his arm.

Katie stood in the doorway, arms crossed, heart thudding.

“So what’s it doing?” he asked, glancing up at her from below.

“It sputters. Then gets loud.”

He grinned. “Like you?”

Her eyes widened. “Excuse me?”

He turned fully toward her, still crouching. “Nothing. Just teasing you.”

“Please don’t,” she said, but her voice was soft and uneven.

He stood slowly, towering over her now in the tight space. Her back touched the doorframe.

“You texted me,” he said. “Middle of the morning.”

“I needed . . .” she started.

“You didn’t need anything,” he said. “You wanted me to come down here.”

She opened her mouth, but nothing came out.

His hand moved to her waist, warm and confident. She didn’t stop him when his fingers slid beneath the hem of her top. His other hand came to rest on the doorframe beside her head.

“You keep leaving the door open,” he said, tracing her skin.

“We shouldn’t.”

“But you want to.”

She didn’t answer.

He leaned down near enough for her breath to catch.

“Just say it, then,” he murmured.

Katie closed her eyes. Her hands clutched his forearms now, but she didn’t push him away. Her body was humming. He hadn’t even kissed her yet, but that thought alone sent another ripple through her.

She felt his breath on her cheek and she tilted her head back slightly.

Then the buzz of Mark’s phone sounded from the bedroom, loud and cheery.

Devin stepped back instantly, his face calm again, the tension erased like it had never happened.

“I’ll check that valve again tomorrow,” he said.

Katie nodded, dizzy.

The door shut behind him.

Mark’s voice called out. “Did someone just leave?”

“Just Devin,,” she said, breathless. “Checking the stupid pipes again.”

Katie didn’t sleep much that night. Every sound from the building felt sharper, closer. She swore she could hear footsteps above, but told herself it was nothing. She curled into Mark’s side, her back against his chest, and stayed awake long after his breathing settled into its usual rhythm. But her body wouldn’t calm down.

The next day was quiet. She half-expected Devin to come by and make good on the valve excuse, but the morning passed without a knock. By mid-afternoon she gave in and wandered up to the rooftop patio with a book she didn’t have any interest in reading, her eyes drifting to the stairwell more than the page.

He still didn’t show.

She stayed until the sun made her too hot, then went back down and found Mark in the living room, tangled in a headset, shooting aliens. He didn’t even look up. She changed into a fresh tank top and no bra, tossed a hoodie over it, and decided to take the recycling out.

Devin was in the hallway, shirtless again, crouched by the breaker box. Something about him always felt rehearsed. His skin was damp from effort or heat or both. He stood as soon as she approached.

“Power flickered upstairs,” he said. “Thought I’d check.”

“Something wrong?”

He shrugged. “Probably not. You okay?”

“I’m fine.”

“You look flushed.”

“It’s hot.”

He smiled, then nodded at her hoodie. “Too many layers.”

She didn’t move.

“I still got that offer open, you know,” he said. “Come up. Just chill. No funny stuff.”

She gave him a look.

“Alright, maybe a little funny stuff.” He waited, watching her face, her hesitation.

“I’m not dressed,” she said.

“You’re perfect.”

She should’ve said no. She told herself she was about to say it. But her feet moved, slow and uncertain, past him and toward the stairs, and once there, she glanced over her shoulder and cleared hair strands from her face. “Well?” she said softly.

Devin followed without a sound. She heard the door to his apartment close behind them, then the turn of the lock. Her heart pounded.

The room was darker than she expected, cooler too. He had one window cracked, a fan on low, soft music playing in the background. She hovered near the entrance, arms crossed.

“Drink?” he asked, already moving to the counter.

She nodded once. “Something light?” She didn’t want to lose control, not yet. He handed her a glass and leaned against the counter, close but not touching. The silence was nearly unbearable.

“You’re not saying much today,” he said finally, grinning.

“I shouldn’t even be here.”

“No big.”

Katie sipped, eyes flicking toward the couch, the hallway beyond it, then back to him. Devin took a step closer.

“I’m not gonna push you,” he said. “But I know you feel it too.”

She didn’t speak, but watched him move around her, her breath drawing shallow, her fingers tightening around the sweating glass.

He reached up and touched her shoulder, lightly. Then slid one hand down her arm, slow and light.

“Tell me to stop,” he said again.

She didn’t. She didn’t even blink.

Devin took her silence like a thread pulled taut. His hand slid lower, trailing from her elbow to her wrist, until his fingers closed around hers, still wrapped around the glass. He guided it gently down to the counter without breaking eye contact, then stepped in closer, chest nearly brushing hers.

Katie’s lips parted, but barely. Her eyes came up only to his chest. Her breath trembled. She should have stepped back, should have said

something, anything. But she didn't. His presence pressed in around her like heat, steady and confident, waiting for her.

When he touched her waist, she moved with him, not resisting, not helping either, just moving together. His other hand rose to her cheek, brushed back a stray lock of hair. She felt the pad of his thumb slide across her jaw, then down the side of her throat. She tilted her chin up, not thinking, just reacting.

The kiss came slow. Not a lunge nor a claim. He hovered there first, just long enough for her to make the final lean. She did, lightly. Their mouths met in a soft, searching press. Her hands stayed at her sides and his stayed on her waist and neck.

And then it deepened. Her hoodie fell open as his hand slid inside. The warmth of his palm found her ribs, then higher. She tensed and he paused. Her lips parted again, and he took that as answer. Her breath caught as his thumb brushed her breast. She arched, but barely. He kissed her harder.

Katie clutched the front of his tank, unsure whether to pull him closer or push him away. She didn't do either. Devin's hand moved with aching slowness, stroking her under the shirt now, cupping her fully, feeling her all over.

Then the sudden ring of her phone burst from her back pocket, vibrating against her spine. They both froze.

She stepped back first.

"Mark," she whispered, already pulling the phone out. "He probably . . ."

Devin stepped back too, his face calm, but his chest rising faster than before.

She turned her back to him as she answered.

"Hey."

"Hey babe," Mark said. "You mind checking the mail while you're down there? I think something from my mom came."

Katie exhaled hard through her nose, heart still hammering.

"Sure," she said. "I'll grab it in a minute."

"Thanks. Love you."

"Love you too."

She hung up. Devin hadn't moved.

"I should go," she said nearly unable to form the words.

He nodded, but didn't speak.

She adjusted her hoodie, wiped her lips with the back of her hand, and moved toward the door.

“Katie,” he said, just as she reached it.

She looked back.

His eyes were darker now. “You’re gonna come back, you know.”

She didn’t answer, didn’t nod, but just left.

In the hallway, her knees nearly gave out. She caught the rail in the staircase, closed her eyes, and breathed in silence.

When she finally got down to the mailbox and back up to the apartment, she went to the bathroom, locked the door, and stared at herself in the mirror.

Her lips were still flushed. Her shirt smelled like his skin.

That night, she let Mark undress her. She didn’t help him, she just lay there and let him peel off her shorts, her hoodie, her panties. He kissed her neck and whispered something sweet, but her eyes were already half-closed. She didn’t fake anything, didn’t exaggerate, but just lay still while he moved inside her.

Her mind wasn’t there at all. She replayed the way Devin had looked at her, the way he’d waited for her, not rushing, not asking. The way her body had leaned into his without her willing it.

Mark came fast like he always did. He kissed her afterward, and she barely kissed him back. Just smiled, turned into the pillow, and let sleep take her while he scrolled beside her.

By morning, she’d convinced herself it wouldn’t happen again, could not happen again, that she’d let it go far enough and now needed to back off before anything serious happened. She kissed Mark’s cheek before he left for his weekend shift, made herself breakfast, opened the windows, and sat down to read awhile.

She was two pages in when she heard footsteps on the stairs. Not hurried, but confident. Familiar.

Her heart raced before she even looked up. A knock and then silence.

Of course she opened the door.

Devin stood there with no tools in his hands no excuse. Just a look.

“Morning, baby,” he said.

She leaned on the frame, arms crossed. “I don’t think you should come in.”

“Okay,” he said. He didn’t move though.

Finally she stepped back, just one foot, her shoulder barely brushing the door. The invitation was slight, but he walked in anyway. “Dummy,” she said.

The door closed behind him. “You been thinking about it?” he asked.

She didn’t lie. “Of course. Nothing but.”

He took two more steps. “You wet when you left yesterday?”

She swallowed hard, but didn’t look away. How could he talk about it like that? So casually.

He touched her chin. “You want more of that today?”

She nodded without hesitation.

And so Devin kissed her again, harder now, not tentatively, not probing. She melted into it immediately, her arms rising, her fingers driving in his hair. He grabbed her ass with both hands, lifter her, walked her backward until her back hit the hallway wall. She gasped against his mouth, then moaned softly as his hands slid under her thighs and pulled her up face to face.

She wrapped her legs around him.

He didn’t take her to the bedroom. He pressed against her right there, hands roaming, mouth on her neck, her collarbone, her chest. Her shirt was pushed up, her breasts bared, his tongue circling each nipple while she clung to his shoulders, panting.

“I want you so bad,” she whispered, unable to stop the words coming out, and she draped her face over his shoulder.

He pulled back, eyes locked on hers. “Then you’re gonna need to tell me everything,” he said. “What you like. What you want.”

“I don’t even know yet,” she simpered.

“I’ll show you what you want then.”

He lowered her to the floor, kneeling as he did. His hands slipped down her hips, then lower, pulling her shorts down, kissing the inside of each thigh as he went.

She closed her eyes and let it happen.

He didn’t rush. He tasted her like he’d been waiting to taste her for weeks. Which he had.

Katie’s hands braced against the wall. Her knees tried to hold, but her whole body trembled under the rhythm of his tongue. Devin had her open, one of her legs draped over his shoulder, his mouth relentless but slow, circling, sucking, teasing every flick into something that made her hips jerk

forward. He didn't say a word. Didn't even look up, just buried himself in her like it was hunger that took him over.

She moaned and kicked her leg involuntarily when he slipped two fingers inside her, making soft, curling strokes that matched the pressure of his mouth. Her breath caught, then shattered with a whimper. She tried to stay quiet, but the heat of it kept rising, flooding over every part of her that hadn't been touched like this in months, or ever.

He glanced up once, eyes dark, jaw wet with her pussy saliva. She wanted to say something, his name, maybe, but the words stuck. He pressed her deeper, slower, and didn't pause this time, even when she slapped the wall behind her, arched her back so deeply, and scrunched her fists in his hair.

She felt it in the soles of her feet, first, a mad spasm that spread through her whole body until she was contracting around his fingers and stomping her heel. Her head banged the wall behind her, her nails cut his shoulder, and she inhaled deeply and held her breath.

Quick, pulsing waves flooded through her, her thighs clenching around his neck, and still he kept going, drawing every last flicker from her until she was gasping, trying to catch air, tapping on his neck to make him stop.

Only then did he slow. He kissed her inner thigh, then the soft hollow above her knee, then stood.

She leaned back against the wall, legs shaking, barely able to hold herself up. Her shorts were around one ankle. Her shirt was twisted high under her armpits. She looked wrecked and didn't bother to fix herself.

Devin pulled her close, his mouth brushing her temple. "You good, baby?" He grinned broadly because he knew that she was.

She nodded against his chest, still breathing hard. She grinned broadly too.

"Should I go?" he asked.

She lifted her head. "No," she said, and she kissed him deeply and long with a face flushed from sweat.

This one wasn't soft. She kissed him like a claim, like something she needed now, both hands on his chest, fingers curling in the fabric, pushing it up to feel his skin. He let her take it off, let her press her body against his skin to skin. His cock was hard through his shorts, thick and ready, and she rocked her hips against it deliberately, wanting him to feel how much she

was past any more hesitation; it wasn't the sort of thing she could say with her voice, not yet.

He gripped her hips and spun her toward the wall, lifted her arms to pin her wrists above her head. She arched deeply, moaning, as he kissed her shoulder, her spine, her lower back. He dropped to his knees again, kissing along the waistband of her panties, which she hadn't even realized she was still wearing. He peeled them down slowly, pausing to bite gently at the crease of her hip.

Then he stood behind her, pulling her ass back into him. "You want me?" he asked close to her ear, his masculinity flooding her.

Katie didn't answer with words. She backed into him, rolling her bare hips into him, teasing herself against the length of him through the fabric that still remained.

He growled low in his throat, then pulled back just enough to drop his shorts and take himself in hand.

She glanced over her shoulder.

"Condom?" she whispered.

He paused.

She reached for her purse on the floor, never breaking eye contact. She was the one who tore the foil.

Devin watched her fingers tear it open with a kind of reverence, his hand still slowly stroking himself. Katie's eyes dropped once to see him fully, and she flushed with a mix of nerves and want so sharp it surprised her. She rolled the condom on without a word, steady hands betraying the beating in her chest.

He stepped forward again, sliding his hands over her waist, her belly, then lower. She braced against the wall, one foot angled out, knees parted enough, back arched, breasts pushed into the cool wall.

The first moment he pressed against her, she inhaled through her teeth. "Easy," he murmured.

"I know," she said. "I know. You easy!"

He slid himself into her slowly. The stretch made her mouth fall open. She had to press her forehead into the wall and breathe herself through it. Devin paused partway, letting her feel it, how full he was, how deep. One of his hands came up to stroke her hair off her neck, the other circled under to cup her breast, thumb brushing rhythmically over her nipple as he sank in the rest of the way.

She gasped when he bottomed out. "Fuck," she whispered.

"You're tight," he said. "You're wet as hell."

"You should talk," she said through panting breath. "You're too big for me."

He smiled against her shoulder and started to move.

At first he kept it slow, his hips rolling in slow, powerful strokes that made her rise onto her toes. Her body opened for him gradually, each push of his a little deeper, smoother, more comfortable. She arched back, and her head turned to the side, trying to take more of him. Always more.

His pace changed, faster now, sharper. She moaned freely and out loud, both hands pressed flat to the wall. His fingers slid down to her clit and he stroked her in time with each thrust.

The flood rushed up from deep in her belly this time, and flowed out in waves of heat throughout her body, and she realized with a startle she was coming again. She'd never orgasmed from intercourse before and it made her hang her mouth open and press her face into the wall.

She cried out loud now completely unrestrained. He grabbed the back of her neck, not to stop her, but to hold her still, pressing her harder into the wall. Her body bucked back against him as she clenched herself around his cock, and he groaned into her skin on the back of her neck, barely keeping rhythm through the spasms of her release.

She stayed standing. She pushed back against him now, more deliberately, grinding her ass against his hips between his thrusts.

"Harder, baby," she said.

"You sure?"

She nodded, breathless now, glancing over her shoulder. Her mouth was flushed and wet, her eyes glazed. "Fuck me harder" she said with her eyes directly on his.

He pulled out halfway, gripped her hips, and slammed himself back in. She gasped and laughed at the same time, stumbling forward slightly, catching herself on the frame of the hallway arch. He followed, crowding her against it, one hand bracing beside hers, the other sliding between her thighs.

The rhythm changed. Nothing was smooth anymore, it was hungry, fast, and sweaty. She didn't care. She matched him thrust for thrust, her hips bouncing off his, her voice rising every time he bottomed out deep inside her. He couldn't hurt her, she was wide open to him.

“Don’t stop,” she breathed. “Just, don’t, stop . . .”

His grip tightened and she could tell he was close.

She met every thrust with her ass. “Come inside me,” she said, her voice hoarse.

He groaned, buried himself deeper, and shuddered. He thrashed her body from his grip around her hips, and she worried about whiplash. She doubled over in front of him and he lifted her off the floor, pounding mercilessly into her. He finally inhaled and groaned, and came hard inside her.

He remained buried in her as his body jerked through the last pulses of his monumental release. Katie’s legs were trembling again, her whole body slumped forward, forehead against the wood frame, breath shaky and unsteady. He kissed the back of her neck, gentler now, quieter, and let his arms wrap around her folded waist from behind. They stayed like that, sticky and quiet, until she reached down and touched his hand.

“I need to sit.”

He helped her down carefully, easing her to the floor. Her thighs were still twitching. She laughed softly and shook her head.

“I can’t feel my knees.”

“That good, huh?” he said and he smirked.

She lay back, hair fanned across the floor, shirt still up, legs bent and open. He watched her for a moment before pulling the condom off, tying it, and walking it to the trash.

When he came back, she still hadn’t moved.

“I’ve never done that before,” she said.

“What, fucked someone?” he said, laughing, joking.

She didn’t answer right away. “No,” she said finally. “Not while still with someone.”

He knelt beside her, brushing her stomach lightly.

“You looked like you wanted it.”

“I did.”

“Then you’re not sorry, right?”

She looked up at him. “I didn’t say I wasn’t.”

“You don’t act like it.”

She sat up, slower now, stretching her back. She pulled her boyfriend’s shirt down and reached for her panties, still hanging from one ankle.

“I need to shower,” she murmured.

She stood on shaky legs and turned toward the door. But before she touched the knob, he was there again, behind her. His hands slid around her hips. He kissed her shoulder, then the side of her neck.

“You still feel it, don’t you,” he said.

She nodded and smiled, cupped her hand around her sore pussy.

He slid two fingers between her legs, feeling how wet and warm she still was. She gasped and leaned back into him.

“I want to see you again,” he said.

“You just did.”

He smiled. “You know what I mean.”

She didn’t argue. She cupped his jaw in her palm and shivered, though she wasn’t cold.

When she slipped out his door, it was into an empty hallway. The building was still and quiet. She padded barefoot down the stairs. At their apartment door, she paused, listening.

No sounds from inside, not yet.

She stepped in quietly. The bedroom door was open and Mark was gone. A note sat on the counter.

“Went out to grab lunch stuff. Back soon.”

She stood staring at the words like they were foreign objects of uncertain origin. Her body still ached, but it wasn’t in a bad way. Her pulse had finally slowed to near normal.

She folded the note and tucked it into the drawer under the microwave. Then she went into the bathroom and turned on the water, stripped and stepped under its warm cascade.

The hot spray hit her shoulders and slid down her back. She tilted her head and closed her eyes, let it flood her face.

When she touched herself, it wasn’t Mark’s name in her head, but it wasn’t guilt either.

It was raw, bare heat. And the sound of a knock still echoing in her bones.

She came out of the shower in a towel and sat on the edge of the bed, steam still rising from her skin, she made it so hot in there. The apartment was still quiet, even though Mark had returned while she was still rinsing, she’d heard the door, the fridge, then the shuffle of him sitting down at his desk again, back in his world of code and Discord.

Two different worlds, she thought to herself.

Her phone buzzed beside her and a single message lit up: “still taste you”
She didn’t answer, but she didn’t delete it either.

Mark’s voice came a few moments later, calling down the hallway. “Hey, you hungry?”

She pulled on a loose tank and shorts, something soft, shapeless, and comfortable. Not sexy, though, not now.

“Famished,” she said, stepping into the kitchen.

He was laying out sandwich stuff like nothing had changed, like his girlfriend’s body wasn’t still throbbing in all the places Devin had touched, licked, and filled. She sat across from him and watched him slice tomatoes, her mind on Devin’s cock expressing so deep inside her.

“I was thinking,” Mark said, “we could take a weekend trip. Just a small one, you and me. Get away from screens.”

She smiled. It was genuine, even if it didn’t reach her quite.

“That sounds nice, Mark, yeah.”

“Maybe next weekend?”

“Sure, so great.”

They ate in silence after that, Katie chewing slowly, distracted by how her body felt shook and loosened under her clothes now. Every movement reminded her of earlier, every shift of her hips, the way the fabric clung between her legs. She had to excuse herself halfway through eating lunch.

In the bathroom, she sat on the edge of the tub and checked her phone again, but it was still just the one message.

She typed a reply, then erased it, then typed again. “you want to see me again?”

No punctuation, nothing more. She stared at it a long time then hit send.

There was no reply for five whole minutes.

Then: “don’t go anywhere tomorrow” and her stomach flipped.

The next morning, Mark kissed her goodbye early, promised to pick up necessities on the way back. She stood at the window in her robe and watched him walk out to the street, his bag over one shoulder, his hoodie half-zipped, care-free and oblivious.

As soon as he turned the corner, she closed the blinds and went to the bedroom.

Her body moved faster than her thoughts. She pulled out the underwear she never wore, the thong with the lace. She pulled out her tight tank. She brushed her hair, then changed her mind and made it a little messy.

She didn't text him, she just walked up the stairs and at Devin's door, she hesitated for the first time. It was momentary. She raised her hand and knocked twice, firm and sure.

The door opened instantly. He didn't smile, he only stepped back.

She walked in straight past him and into his apartment that already felt like something she knew.

He shut the door behind her and didn't lock it. She knew they wouldn't be interrupted.

She didn't stop walking until she reached the middle of the room. The same fan was spinning, the same dim light slanted through the blinds. But this time, she wasn't waiting for him to come to her.

She turned slowly. Devin was still by the door, watching her, arms relaxed at his sides, a small grin on his face. He knew what this was: he had awakened her.

She peeled her tank off first, pulling it up over her head in one smooth motion and letting it drop behind her. The lace underneath wasn't shy. Pale pink, sheer, cut high. She'd never worn it for Mark.

Devin moved toward her without a word. His hands landed on her hips, sliding over the band of her panties, then lower, cupping her ass as he kissed her. Her arms wrapped around his shoulders, mouth open, tongue moving with his now, urgent and eager. There was nothing soft this time. No pause. No resistance. When he walked her backward toward the couch, she followed without hesitation.

He pulled her panties down as she sat. She lifted her hips to help then leaned back, legs falling open.

"Take them off," she said, nodding at his shorts.

He did.

She took his cock in both hands, watching it twitch under her touch. She leaned forward and wrapped her lips around him, slowly at first, then deeper, guiding him in with a rhythm that made his jaw clench and his hands tighten in her hair.

"You're gonna make me come," he warned.

But she didn't stop. She sucked harder, let him hit the back of her throat, eyes locked on his as she took more and more, hands stroking the base, her breath coming through her nose now as she worked him with total focus. He groaned, loud, raw, and close.

"Stop," he said, pulling back suddenly, shaking his head. "Not yet."

She wiped her mouth with the back of her hand and grinned. "Then fuck me, asshole."

He lifted her clear off the couch and turned her around without a word. He bent her forward over the armrest, spread her legs with his knees, and ran his fingers between her folds.

"Soaked," he said.

"I know. I was thinking of you all morning."

He slid in deep, both hands gripping her hips, no teasing this time. Just thick, full strokes that made the couch creak and her breath catch with every thrust. Her hair fell over her face as she held the cushion, bracing herself.

He fucked her so hard she whimpered.

Then he lifted her upright, pulled her into his lap, and sat down with her riding him, her knees straddling his thighs. She ground against him, slower this time, rolling her hips in slow circles, his hands sliding up her back, her sides, her breasts. She kissed him messy, open-mouthed, panting into him.

"I want you to make me come again," she whispered.

He shifted under her, angled himself deeper in her, then started bouncing her on his cock with both hands on her ass, letting her ride him hard now, her cries rising in his ear as she clung to his shoulders and begged for more.

Her legs trembled uncontrollably, her head buried against his neck. Her fingernails dug into his shoulders as her body locked up around his cock, waves crashing through her, longer and harder than anything before. She let out a broken moan that turned into laughter at the end, delirious, sweaty, stunned at how fast it had built and come.

Devin didn't stop. He kissed her shoulder, then her collarbone, his hips still moving up into her, drawing every last twitch out of her.

"I can't," she breathed, giggling now. "I'm gonna fall apart."

He lifted her easily, laying her back on the couch, then pulled her legs up, resting them over his shoulders. She blinked up at him, dazed.

"You said all the way," he said.

She nodded once. He slid back in.

This position was deeper, maybe too deep. She gasped and grabbed at the cushion above her head, legs shaking as he started pounding into her body again, holding her hips in place while his cock slammed against the softest, most sensitive spot inside her over and over. It was too much, but she didn't want him to stop.

She cried out again, eyes shut, face flushed, chest heaving. Every time he drove forward, her breath caught. Her hands clenched into fists beside her head.

Devin watched her face, jaw tight, sweat beading at his temples. He was close again.

“I want to see you come,” she said and she gasped at her own words.

The slap of skin on skin filled the room, slick and wet, her arousal making every thrust obscene. She wasn’t shy anymore, she let him hear her. She wanted him to.

She started to break again, her back arching up, legs kicking weakly over his shoulders.

“Oh my god, Devin,” she gasped.

He fucked her through it, hard and fast, until her whole body seized under him. Her moan hit the ceiling, and she grabbed both sides of the couch frame to anchor herself, eyes squeezed shut as she rode the explosion all the way down.

He pulled out fast, flipped her onto her stomach, and dragged her hips up in front of him. She reached back automatically, opening for him, searching for him. He slid into her from behind, grabbing both her wrists and pinning them behind her back, bending over her as he drove in deep.

It was rough now, and desperate. He was chasing his own finish and using every inch of her to get there.

She moaned into the cushion. Her body was wrecked, used, soaking wet, and still hungry.

He lost it with his forehead pressed between her shoulder blades. He grunted once, twice, then froze, twitching inside her, his grip tightening on her wrists as he emptied himself into the condom again, grinding his hips until the last of it pulsed out.

They collapsed together and neither moved. Her face was turned sideways on the couch. His chest was on her back, both panting.

It was the quiet that came after that made her smile. Devin finally rolled off her, pulling the condom off, and knotting it without a word. He disappeared down the hall and returned with a towel, warm from the dryer. Katie let him press it between her legs, laughing quietly at how tender she’d become.

“I’m not gonna walk right for hours,” she said.

“Good,” he muttered, crouching beside the couch, brushing a thumb under her eye. “You look good and fucked.”

“I am good and fucked, thanks you,” she said and she playfully pressed her foot into his chest.

She sat up slowly, limbs heavy and loose. Her tank top was half off, her panties somewhere across the room, her body marked with pink handprints and faint bruises from his grip. Her thighs were streaked and wet, her hair a mess. She looked like everything she wasn’t supposed to be.

And she liked it badly.

She sipped water from a glass he brought her and he stayed close, watching her with a satisfied calm that made her pulse stir again even though she was wrecked.

When she finally stood, her legs wobbled and she had to grab the back of the couch.

“Shut up,” she said, grinning.

“I didn’t say anything.”

“You were thinking it.”

He grinned. “You gonna sneak back down like that?”

Katie looked toward the window. The sun had shifted, there was still time.

“I need to,” she said. “He’ll be back soon.”

Devin stood behind her, resting both hands on her waist. “You gonna come back tomorrow?”

She looked down. “I don’t know yet.”

“You will.”

She didn’t argue. He kissed her shoulder, slower this time, gentle. Then her neck, then the base of her spine. Each kiss deliberate, each one sending a fresh ripple through muscles already drained.

“Okay, maybe,” she said and she chuckled. When she dressed, she didn’t rush. She took her time, even adjusting her hair in his mirror, watching his reflection as he watched her. There wasn’t shame, not even guilt. Just a weight, a secret she now carried in her hips, in the way her lips felt fuller, her skin flushed deeper.

At the door, she paused. “I’m never going to tell him.”

“I never thought you would.”

“But you don’t care, do you?”

Devin shrugged. “Just come back.”

She opened the door and stepped into the hallway barefoot. Her legs were sore, her thighs sticky despite the towel, and she felt stretched in a way that made every step feel wobbly.

At the apartment, she listened before entering. The kitchen was quiet, no voices, no typing. She slipped inside, locked the door behind her, and dropped her keys into the bowl by the door.

Mark wasn't home yet. She padded to the bathroom, stripped again, and stepped into the shower for the second time that day.

When Mark returned twenty minutes later with sandwiches she was on the couch in fresh clothes, legs folded, book open in her lap.

She looked up, smiled, and kissed him on the cheek. "What did you get us?"

"One chicken, one egg salad, which one you want?"

"Whichever came first," she said. "Of course."

When he started the movie, she said, "You should stay home tomorrow. You should."

"Got a thing," he said and he shrugged.

She squeezed his foot where it pressed against her hip, turned to the screen, and looked at it without watching it.